

Beyond Simandou

The Productive Republic — A Doctrine for the Guinean State

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Half Title

BEYOND SIMANDOU

A Doctrine for Statecraft · Guinea 2026

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Beyond Simandou: The Productive Republic — A Doctrine for the Guinean State

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Dedication

*For the most capable of a generation —
the ones who did everything the country asked,
and were offered only one road out.
May they find, at home, the reward for building
that they once had to seek abroad.*

Epigraph

“A nation develops when productive activity becomes more rewarding than political access.”

THE MINES ARE NOT THE TEST.

THE STATE IS THE TEST.

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What This Doctrine Is

This is a doctrine. It describes what the Guinean state must become, and why, in terms meant to hold for any leader who would build it and any citizen who would demand it. It is not a plan, and it does not pretend to be one. A plan belongs to a government and a moment; a doctrine must outlast both. What follows is therefore a description of an end and the principles that reach it — not a schedule for arriving.

From this, three things follow, and they are choices, not omissions. It carries no implementation timetable, because the same doctrine must serve a leader governing under conditions no one today can foresee, and a schedule written now would be wrong the moment those conditions changed; where it asks for a rule, it fixes a principle and a priority, never a precise figure the next decade would embarrass. It rests on few numbers and holds them loosely, because an argument that stands on a statistic falls when the statistic is revised, and the figures here are present to convey scale, not to bear the weight of the case. And it assigns no blame and takes no side — it names no person, party, region, or community as the villain of Guinea's story, and no country as the author of its troubles, because a doctrine that names a side becomes the property of that side and is discarded when the side falls, while the patterns it describes belong to none of them and recur across them all. But naming a villain and naming an example are opposite acts, and the doctrine does the second freely and without apology. It will point to the country that disciplined its resource wealth and the one that squandered it, to the neighbor whose trade Guinea

must win, to the leader who once held absolute power and gave it back into institutions — because evidence is not blame and an example is not a side. To refuse these would not be neutrality; it would be the doctrine throwing away its own proof. What it withholds is accusation. What it offers, gladly, is whatever the world's record can teach about meeting the test Guinea now faces.

Read it, then, as a standard to be met rather than a program to be administered: the description of a state clear enough that those who pursue it and those who watch them can both measure how far the country has come.

Before the Doctrine

For half a century, Guinea has been one of the world's foremost exporters of bauxite — among the largest anywhere — and through all of it the average citizen has lived on barely more than a dollar a day.

The ore left. The poverty stayed.

What failed was never the geology. It was the state. That single fact is the whole of this doctrine: a country does not become rich by selling what lies under its ground, but by building the state that decides what becomes of the wealth. The mines are not the test. The state is the test.

The Doctrine in One Page

For the reader who has three minutes.

The Claim. Guinea remains underdeveloped not because it lacks resources but because its reward system has made political access more profitable than productive activity. Talent, capital, and ambition flow toward controlling access to value rather than creating it. Development begins when that reward system is reversed.

The Principle — National Rule Zero. Every policy, institution, and investment must be judged against one question: does this make productive activity more rewarding relative to political access, or less? This rule supersedes all others.

The Three National Rules.

- **Rule Zero** — Productive activity must become more rewarding than political access.
- **Rule One** — Never spend faster than the state's capacity to execute.
- **Rule Two** — Capability must precede capital, on both sides of every transaction.

Corridor Logic. Think in economies, not roads — and earn every corridor against real competitors rather than assuming the map confers it. Infrastructure built for a mine must be open by right to those who did not finance it, or it stays a private siding rather than a national spine.

The Test. Are more Guineans creating value than controlling access to value? When the answer is yes, the doctrine is working. When the answer is no, something has been captured.

The mines are not the test. The state is the test.

The Shape of the Argument

One claim, in three movements, and one test.

The claim. Guinea remains underdeveloped not because it lacks resources, plans, or laws, but because its reward system pays more for controlling access to value than for creating it.

One — the reward is inverted. Talent, capital, and ambition flow to the gate, not the workshop, because that is where the reward sits. This is not a failure of character; it is a rational response to the incentives as they are.

Two — so two maps diverge. There is the official map — the laws, the codes, the fund, the corridor, the program — and the real map of who actually gets what, and through whom. The real one governs. Reform that changes only the official map changes nothing.

Three — so the best instruments cannot bind. Guinea already has excellent laws, plans, and funds. They do not work — not because they are badly drawn, but because making them bind would mean turning the state against the access economy that rewards the very people who would have to enforce them. The gap between the two maps is the disease.

The test. Are more Guineans creating value than controlling access to it? When the answer is yes, the doctrine is working. When it is no, something has been captured.

The mines are not the test. The state is the test.

Preface: Why This Document Exists

Guinea does not lack plans. Guinea has produced national visions, poverty reduction strategies, sectoral roadmaps, mining frameworks, agricultural programs, and development conferences for decades.

None of them failed because they lacked ambition.

They failed because they did not confront the system they were trying to change.

Consider one young man — there are hundreds of thousands like him, so he needs no name. He finished his degree. He was capable, willing, and ready to build something. He looked for a way to turn his ability into a living and found that the doors that mattered did not open to competence. They opened to connection. The contracts, the licenses, the positions, the capital all moved through proximity to people with power, and he had none. He did everything the country told a young person to do, and the country had no productive place to put him. So he sold what he owned and bought passage on the long route north, toward somewhere that might reward what he could do. He was not the most desperate of his generation. He was among the most capable. That is the point. The system did not fail to give him a path. It gave him only one — out.

This doctrine is about the country that produced that choice, and about the reward system that made leaving more rational than building. Everything in the pages that follow exists to change the calculation that put him on that road.

Guinea's problem is not the absence of good intentions. It is the presence of a reward system that defeats them systematically — that bends every road into an inflated contract, every license into a political asset, every reform into a new form of the old arrangement.

Until that reward system changes, plans will continue to fail.

Everything between the claim and the test is the work.

Part I: The Misallocation

Guinea's condition has been described for fifty years and cured by none — because every diagnosis has named a symptom, and none will name the disease.

The Wrong Diagnosis

Most analyses of Guinea's underdevelopment begin with symptoms. Corruption. Weak institutions. Poor infrastructure. Low human capital. Aid dependency. Bad governance.

These observations are accurate. They are not explanations.

They describe what Guinea looks like. They do not explain why Guinea keeps producing the same outcomes despite different governments, different plans, and different revenue levels.

The explanation requires going one level deeper.

The Mechanism

Guinea has repeatedly failed to develop not because it lacks resources, not because its people lack capability, and not because development is impossible in West Africa.

Guinea has repeatedly failed to develop because its reward system has systematically directed talent, capital, and ambition away from productive activity and toward the control of access.

This is not a moral failure. It is a rational response to incentives — the same talent flowing into building or into capture depending only on which a society rewards. Economists have a name for this pattern; this doctrine reached it from Guinea’s own evidence, and offers the convergence as confirmation, not as borrowing.

When the highest returns in an economy flow not from producing value but from controlling access to value — access to licenses, contracts, exemptions, land, customs channels, procurement decisions, import monopolies, and resource rents — rational actors pursue access rather than production.

Talented young people seek proximity to power before developing expertise. Businesses invest in relationships before building competitiveness. Capital flows toward rent extraction rather than value creation. Engineers become fixers, entrepreneurs become intermediaries, manufacturers become importers, and innovators become political clients.

The country generates brokers faster than it generates producers.

This is the true development challenge of Guinea. Not the absence of wealth. The systematic misallocation of talent, capital, and ambition toward access rather than production.

The Scale of the Emergency

This is not a slow-moving problem. Every year, hundreds of thousands of young Guineans enter a labor market that cannot absorb them productively. The median age in Guinea is 18. More than half the population has never known an economy that rewarded production over access. Across that generation, a large share of the young are neither in work, in school, nor in training — by the available estimates, something on the order of a third, and markedly higher among young women than young men. They are not idle by choice. They are rational actors responding to a system that offers them no productive pathway. The deeper signal is that the young overwhelm-

ingly judge that the state has failed to create work for them — not because they are ungrateful, but because they are accurately describing a system that has not converted Guinea’s resource wealth into productive opportunity for the generation that will determine the country’s future. Where it has been measured, that disapproval runs to the overwhelming majority of them.

The most dangerous consequence of this failure is not unemployment. It is emigration. When Guinea’s broken reward system fails its most entrepreneurial young people, they do not disappear into quiet poverty. The motivated ones leave. The Mediterranean crossing and the Nicaragua route to the United States are not taken by the most desperate. They are taken by the most resourceful — the young people with enough capital, networks, and initiative to attempt the journey. These are precisely the people the productive economy needs most. Guinea’s broken reward system is therefore not merely failing to capture entrepreneurial talent. It is actively exporting it to other countries’ productive economies. Every year this continues, the productive economy becomes weaker, which makes the reward system harder to change, which drives more emigration. This is the feedback loop that makes urgency not a rhetorical choice but an analytical conclusion.

Where Talent Flows

The ultimate measure of a development model is not GDP growth. It is where talent flows.

A country develops when its most ambitious young people choose to become engineers rather than brokers, entrepreneurs rather than intermediaries, agronomists rather than rent-seekers, manufacturers rather than political clients, scientists rather than fixers.

When talent flows toward production, prosperity compounds. When talent flows toward access, stagnation compounds.

The nations that succeeded all, in their own way, eventually reckoned with this. Guinea must do the same. And it must do so now, because the demographic mathematics of delay are unforgiving.

The country generates brokers faster than it generates producers. The work is to reverse that.

Part II: The Three Economies

A country is not rich or poor by what it owns, but by which of its three economies its people are rewarded for serving.

Every nation contains three economies operating simultaneously.

The Natural Economy is the endowment provided by geography and geology: bauxite, iron ore, gold, diamonds, rivers, forests, fertile land, a young population, and access to the Atlantic. Guinea possesses this economy in extraordinary abundance. This is not the problem.

The Political Economy is the system of returns generated through controlling access: licenses, permits, concessions, exemptions, monopolies, procurement decisions, land allocations, and state resources. In Guinea, this economy is far larger than it should be. It absorbs too much talent, too much capital, and too much ambition that the productive economy requires.

The Productive Economy is the system of returns generated through creating value: farming, manufacturing, construction, logistics, engineering, entrepreneurship, services, and innovation. This is the economy that creates durable prosperity. This is the economy that employs most citizens. This is the economy that must grow.

The central task of the next generation is precise: move the center of gravity of Guinean ambition from the political economy into the productive economy.

Underused Capacity

One exclusion is larger than any single rent-seeking network, because it operates not against a faction but against half the population. Women perform much of Guinea's productive work — by the national agricultural survey, a majority of the labor in its largest sector — yet are held at the margin of the economy they help carry. This is the access economy operating at the scale of gender: not a barrier of law, for the law forbids none of it, but the familiar gap between a right that exists on paper and an outcome that does not exist in practice — talent that wants to produce, prevented from producing by arrangements it did not choose.

The doctrine's whole claim is that artificial barriers between people and production are the disease, and this is the largest such barrier in the country, standing between the economy and the full use of the people already doing its work. A state that develops half its population and sidelines the other half is not merely unjust; it is competing against its own capacity, financing the education of women whose output it then declines to use. The remedy is not a program bolted onto this doctrine but the doctrine applied without exception: every rule here — secure title, open credit, reward for production over access — must be measured by whether it widens the ability of women to own, build, and grow from what they produce, or narrows it. National Rule Zero is not met while half the country is governed by a reward system the other half escaped.

National Rule Zero

Every policy, institution, investment, and reform must be evaluated against one question:

Does this make productive activity more rewarding relative to political access, or less?

This rule supersedes every other rule, every ministry's preference, every election cycle's pressure, and every foreign advisor's recommendation. Because development begins — and only begins — when this condition is met.

Governing Question · The Elite Capture Paradox

The doctrine establishes that Guinea's political economy rewards access over production, and that reform requires dismantling the networks that extract value from that arrangement. The difficulty it cannot resolve is that the people who would have to carry out these reforms are inside the system the reforms would dismantle.

If you are reading this from within that system, the doctrine is written with you in mind — not the many who will defend the arrangement to the end, but the few who have lived inside it, benefited from it, and still want it changed. It does not insult you by pretending the ask is small. To sign the Resource Constitution is to sign away discretion you currently hold. To digitize procurement is to dissolve the opacity that makes your office worth courting. To accept the separation of armed power from commerce is to give up a position that feeds people who depend on you. These are not abstractions; they are losses, borne by a specific person with obligations, allies, and a family.

What it asks is not that you feel guilty for where you stand, but that you use where you stand to move the system — because your position, the very thing that compromises you, is also what gives you the leverage almost no one else has. This understanding is offered to steel the one who would act, not to comfort the one who would not: anyone who reads it as permission to keep taking has read it exactly backward, because everything in it is about how to move, and nothing in it excuses standing still.

The question the doctrine cannot answer for you is how genuine reform emerges from inside the thing being reformed, and how to tell

those who have truly turned from those who have only learned the words. What it can give you is the one standard that cuts through both: does this specific act move the reward system toward production, or away from it?

Apply it to others. Apply it, harder, to yourself.

Part III: Simandou Is a Stress Test, Not a Strategy

Guinea has run this experiment before. The ore left and the poverty stayed. The mine is not the test; the state is.

The Historical Record

The history of development contains countries that became rich in resources without becoming prosperous. Nigeria earned hundreds of billions from petroleum. Most citizens remained poor. Venezuela used oil revenues to build popular support and import dependency. When prices fell, the state collapsed. The Democratic Republic of Congo sits atop extraordinary mineral wealth while its people remain among the poorest on earth.

At the same time, Botswana used diamond revenues to build institutions and infrastructure. Norway used oil revenues to build a sovereign fund and a diversified economy. South Korea and Singapore transformed themselves with far fewer natural advantages through disciplined industrial policy and institutional investment.

The mineral content of the ground did not determine these outcomes. The institutional quality of the state did.

Guinea does not need to look abroad for the proof; it has been running this experiment on itself for half a century, and the bauxite decades are worth examining closely, because they show exactly how the failure works. In the years when exports rose most steeply, the

revenue reaching the state scarcely moved — and the reason is the whole lesson. The wealth was priced below its worth, routed around the public account, and captured by domestic and foreign hands before it ever became schools, power, or capacity. The shortfall was not bad luck or low prices; it was structural, the predictable yield of a weak state confronted with a valuable resource. This is the decisive fact, and it is not a forecast but a record: at the scale of its largest industry, Guinea has already discovered that exporting more of a resource is not the same as becoming a richer country. The ore moved; the capacity never formed. And what determined that was never the geology under the ground but the institutions above it.

The Real Question

Most discussions about Simandou focus on how much revenue it will generate. This is the wrong question.

Simandou changes the scale of the question, not its nature. The iron ore has now begun to move, and its output will build toward full capacity over the coming years — so the revenue is no longer a distant prospect but a rising tide already starting to come in. Yet it poses exactly the test that bauxite has been posing all along, only larger. The same state that could not convert decades of bauxite into national capacity will now be handed a far greater flow to convert, or to lose. Simandou is not a new test. It is the old one, with the stakes raised.

The right question is: will Guinea's institutions prove stronger than its rent-seeking networks when the money arrives?

Simandou is not Guinea's development strategy. Simandou is Guinea's institutional stress test.

If institutions are stronger, Simandou finances transformation. If rent-seeking networks are stronger, Simandou finances a larger, more expensive, and ultimately more disappointing version of what already exists.

The Greatest Danger

The greatest danger of the Simandou era is not that the mine fails financially. The greatest danger is that the mine succeeds financially while failing developmentally — generating revenue that flows through the political economy before it reaches the productive economy, leaving behind dependency, inflation, inequality, and eventual disappointment.

Guinea has one window to prevent this outcome, and it is open now precisely because the flow has only just begun. It is widest before the new rents have set — before expectations harden, before networks entrench around the iron the way they long ago entrenched around the bauxite, before the new arrangements become the new normal. Every month of the ramp that passes without the institutions in place is a month in which the old pattern reattaches itself to the new wealth.

That window is now.

Core Doctrine

Mining is not the strategy. Mining finances the strategy.

Governing Question • The Political Survival Question

The doctrine can hand you the sequence of reform and the institutions to protect it. What it cannot hand you is how to survive the valley — the stretch between the moment reform's costs land on the powerful and the far later moment its benefits reach the people whose support would shield you. This is the question that has ended more reforms than any other, and it must be stated without flinching: the reformer who walks into it unprepared is the reformer who does not walk out.

The asymmetry is the whole danger. The costs come first and they come fast: the Resource Constitution takes revenue from connected

people who feel the loss immediately; customs reform closes income streams that fund political networks; separating armed power from commerce will be resisted by the one institution capable of ending a government. The benefits come last and come slow — the productive economy shows no visible return for years, and when it finally does, your successor may harvest the credit. So the doctrine is asking you to absorb concentrated, immediate, organized hostility in exchange for diffuse, delayed, and possibly unclaimed reward, and it will not pretend that is anything but one of the hardest trades a person in power can be asked to make.

It names this plainly so that you do not feel alone or naive in finding it hard; the difficulty is real, and naming it is not the same as excusing the refusal to face it. Some caution here is wisdom — move too fast and you can break a fragile state rather than fix it. But be honest with yourself, because the protection of one's own position wears the costume of prudence more often than not, and the reader best served by this doctrine is the one willing to tell the difference in his own case.

The practical counsel begins with a single rule the rest follows from: do not impose every cost at once, or you unite the whole network against you in a single season. How to stage what comes after — which allies to build before which enemies are made, how to keep the coalition with you larger than the one against you, when to deliver the visible benefit that shields you — is the art, and it is best taken up through the oldest source on it.

Five centuries ago Machiavelli gave a prince the other half of this counsel, and it is worth taking up deliberately rather than stumbling into. Confer benefits gradually, he said, so each is savored; but inflict all necessary injuries at once, so they are felt together and resented less. This doctrine keeps his rule on benefits and breaks it on injuries — and the break is deliberate. Machiavelli was teaching a prince how to hold power; this doctrine is teaching a reformer how to give it away into institutions, and the two aims part exactly here. A conqueror can

afford to wound everyone at once because he means to rule them afterward by fear. A reformer cannot, because he needs many of the wounded to live and work inside the state he is building, and an enemy made permanent is a reform made fragile. So the costs are sequenced, not massed: the aim is not to cow the network in a single blow but to take it apart faster than it can combine. On the people, though, the old counsel holds without amendment — their favor, won by visible benefit, is the shield against the great, exactly as it was in his century and ours.

None of this guarantees survival. It is what a serious person brings to a fight he may still lose — and the judgment of how to combine it belongs to you, in your moment, which no one writing in advance can see.

Mining is not the strategy.

Mining finances the strategy.

Part IV: The Sequence

Do everything at once and you finish nothing. The right things built in the wrong order leave debt where there should have stood assets.

Why sequence matters

A productive state is not built by doing everything simultaneously. It is built in sequence, because each layer of capability enables the next, and money spent before the enabling layer exists produces cost overruns, captured institutions, and permanent debt rather than permanent assets. This is the principle the whole chapter turns on, and it is the one Guinea has most often violated: capital arriving in floods against institutions that could absorb a trickle, and the gap between the money and the capacity to use it filled, as it has always been filled, by extraction.

The constraint is not the amount of investment but its order. Capability must precede the capital it is meant to absorb. Foundations must precede what is built on them. A state that funds consumption before productive capacity, or vanity before foundations, does not accelerate development — it converts its windfall into debt with a ribbon-cutting ceremony. The discipline of sequence is the difference between money that becomes an asset and money that becomes a liability.

Allocation by rule, not by number

How a state divides its resource revenue should be fixed by a published rule, not by discretion and not by a permanent number. A government that publishes its order of priorities binds its own discretion, which is the entire purpose. A government that fixes a precise split for all time binds itself to a figure circumstance will soon make wrong. So the rule is an order of priority, not a set of percentages: productive capacity funded before consumption; a real share always saved against the day the ore runs out or its price collapses; and the communities nearest the extraction protected from bearing its costs while distant centers take its benefits. The precise weights belong to the government that sets them, defended openly against the conditions of its moment. What cannot be surrendered is the discipline of allocating by rule at all.

What sequence looks like in practice

The logic is visible in the order the foundations must come. Reliable power precedes almost everything, because agro-processing, manufacturing, cold storage, hospitals, and industrial production all depend on it — and the priority is not megawatts for ceremonies but electricity delivered, billed, maintained, and commercially sustainable. Logistics follows, chosen by economic logic rather than political pressure: roads selected by patronage are not development but redistribution to construction intermediaries, and a corridor without a maintenance budget is a liability, not an asset. Infrastructure built for a mine must be conceived from the first day as national common-carrier capacity open to agriculture and general freight, never as a single company's private siding — because a railway that carries only ore is the access economy rendered in steel, while one that also carries a farmer's harvest is the productive economy. Skills follow infrastructure, because a state that must import every technician for every project has not industrialized; and agriculture, where the binding loss is not in the

field but between the field and the market — Guinea does not need to grow more food before it can reduce hunger, it needs to stop losing the food it already grows — for a country that imports food while sitting on fertile land has not yet understood sovereignty. Only on those foundations does industrialization rest, built where natural advantages are real rather than where ambition is loudest.

None of this is a ranked program to be funded line by line. It is the logic of dependence: each layer makes the next possible, and capital that races ahead of the capability to absorb it does not build the next layer — it is captured in the gap. That is the whole of the principle, and the reason sequence is not bureaucratic caution but the difference between assets and debt.

A rule binds; a number merely dates.

Part V: The Resource Constitution

The rules that govern the wealth must be written before it arrives. Constitutions written during the flood are written by people already wet.

Resource wealth frequently destroys the institutions it was meant to strengthen. Guinea must therefore build its Resource Constitution before the full revenue wave arrives. Not after. Before. Constitutions written before the flood have a chance of holding. Those written during it are written by people the water has already reached, bargaining with the very forces the rules were meant to bind.

There is a deeper reason than waste, and it is the one most often missed. A state funded by what it digs out of the ground does not need to tax its people — and a state that does not need to tax its people slowly stops needing them at all. The quiet bargain at the foundation of every accountable government is this: the state asks its citizens for revenue, and in exchange must answer to them for how it is spent. Tax is not only how a government is funded; it is the thread that ties it to the governed. Sever that thread — let the treasury fill from a mine instead of from the people — and the government can fund itself, reward its friends, and secure its position without ever requiring the consent, the productivity, or even the goodwill of its citizens. This is why resource wealth so often hardens into unaccountable power rather than dissolving into mere theft: the ore does not simply tempt the state to steal, it frees the state from the one discipline that made it serve. Guinea must understand the stakes in these terms. The Resource

Constitution is not only a wall against waste; it is the deliberate refusal to let mineral revenue cut the cord between the state and the people it exists to serve. By forcing resource wealth through published rules, parliamentary approval, and a citizen's right to see the accounts, the Constitution keeps the thread of accountability intact where the ore would otherwise quietly cut it.

This is the place where the gap between the two maps is widest and most dangerous — because here the official map is at its most convincing. A state in the resource era will write the rules. It will create the protected account, mandate the disclosure, promise the audit, build the fund. It may write them well; it may take the best advice in the world on how to write them. None of that is the test. The rules that bind mineral wealth do not fail because they are badly drafted. They fail because binding the wealth means binding the people the wealth rewards — and those are the same people who hold the pen. A protected account can be raided by the authority that built it. A disclosure rule discloses nothing if no one with power is ever charged. A fund “separate from the budget” relocates discretion rather than constraining it the moment the reward for capturing it exceeds the cost. The constraint is only ever as real as the willingness to enforce it against the connected — and that willingness is precisely what the reward system, left unchanged, removes.

So the Resource Constitution names not five things to build but one thing that must become true: mineral revenue must be bound by rules that bind the powerful, and a rule that the powerful can route around is not a constraint but a decoration. Three principles follow, and each is a description of what binding means, not an instruction in how to draft it.

Visibility

Opacity is the infrastructure of theft. Wherever the flow of resource wealth is hidden — in a contract, an exemption, a concession, a

procurement — the hiding is not discretion to be negotiated; it is the mechanism by which the public's wealth becomes a private network's income. A state serious about binding its wealth makes the flow visible, because what cannot be seen cannot be defended, and what is not defended is taken.

Separation

Revenue that flows straight to discretion severs the state from the governed. Wealth that reaches a treasury free of any rule about how it must be set aside, justified, and accounted for is wealth that funds the state without binding it — and a state funded without being bound is a state freed from its people. To bind the wealth is to interrupt that flow with rules that outrank the convenience of the moment.

The Limit of Force

Armed power must never become a commercial actor or the gatekeeper of the economy. No productive state can function when the monopoly on force stands over its ports, its customs, its licenses — whether by owning them or by deciding who may operate them. The role of armed authority is to protect the republic, not to price admission to it. The moment force becomes a toll on commerce, every reform downstream of it is theater.

These are not a checklist. A checklist is what Guinea already has — written, enacted, advised by the best in the world, and routinely unenforced. The Resource Constitution is the standard by which any such instrument is judged: not whether it was written, but whether it binds the people it was written to bind. On the current reward system, it will not. That is not a prediction about any particular fund or law. It is the mechanism, and it will hold until the mechanism changes.

Governing Question · The Institutional Sequencing Paradox

Every constraint this doctrine describes leans on the others. Binding mineral revenue needs a parliament capable of overseeing how it is spent. Saving against the future needs managers insulated from the political pressure to spend now. Securing land needs a civil service able to keep an honest record. Separating armed power from commerce needs civilian bodies strong enough to take over what that power now controls. Each depends on the others being at least partly real before it can itself become real — which is why a reform attempted in isolation so often fails, and why the reward system, which sits beneath all of them at once, is the only point at which the whole interlocking structure can be moved.

If you are the person holding this, you are likely looking at several missing foundations at once and being told, in effect, that each one requires the others first. The doctrine will not pretend there is a clean order that dissolves the bind, because there is not; this is among the hardest sequencing problems in the whole of development practice, and anyone who hands you a confident universal sequence is selling something.

What it can tell you honestly is that the bind is real, that being stuck at it is not a failure of your competence but the genuine structure of the problem, and that the way through is not a formula but judgment — your judgment, informed by what residual institutional capacity actually exists in Guinea today, by where a first credible win can be secured to make the next one possible, and by the particular order in which trust can be built with the people whose cooperation each institution requires.

The doctrine gives you the map of what must be built. Which corner to begin in, when everything depends on everything, is yours to judge — and the honest acknowledgment that there is no general

answer is meant to free you from the false standard of finding one, not to excuse the refusal to begin.

Capability must
precede capital.

Part VI: The State Capacity Trap

A state can receive money faster than it can spend it well. When it does, the government grows richer as the state grows weaker — and no one notices until the assets turn out to be debts.

National Rule One

Never spend faster than the state's capacity to execute.

A delayed project is frustrating. A failed project becomes a permanent liability — debt without asset, cost without capability.

Resource-rich states frequently receive capital faster than they develop institutions capable of managing it productively. Projects multiply faster than oversight. Contracts multiply faster than procurement expertise. Budgets expand faster than execution capability. The government appears richer. The state does not become stronger.

Guinea has already lived this trap. Across the country, much of the agricultural machinery provided by the government or international donors sits inactive — not because farmers do not need it, but because the institutional capacity to maintain it, supply spare parts for it, and train mechanics to repair it was never built alongside it. The machines exist. They do not work.

The same pattern repeats wherever money arrives ahead of capacity: agricultural credit lines and guarantee funds established to finance rural enterprise that disbursed large sums while the institutions meant

to govern them lacked the risk management, the auditing, and the verification to know whether the money reached a real producer or vanished into a paper one. The investment was real. The capability to govern it was not. This is the State Capacity Trap made visible — in iron and rust in the fields, and in funds that cannot account for what they spent — and it will repeat itself at far greater scale in infrastructure, energy, and industrial projects if the sequence is not respected.

Every major investment must pass not only a financial test but an implementation test: Can the responsible Guinean institution realistically design, procure, supervise, maintain, and evaluate this project successfully with current capacity? If the answer is no, one of two things must happen: the institution builds the capacity first, or the project waits.

National Rule Two — The Absorption Principle

Capability must precede capital.

The State Capacity Trap has a twin that is easy to mistake for simple theft. When capital is deployed before the capacity to use it productively exists, the failure is not on one side of the transaction. It is on both. The institution providing the money lacks the systems to govern it. The recipient lacks the capability to convert it into production. And when neither side can use money productively, extraction becomes the only profitable thing left to do with it. This is the deepest reason premature financialization breeds corruption: not because the people involved are uniquely dishonest, but because a system that cannot produce value from capital will reliably select for those who can divert it. Corruption, in this light, is not a separate disease from the capability gap. It is what the capability gap looks like once the money arrives.

A zero-interest loan handed to someone with no business plan, no bookkeeping, no market, and no execution capacity does not create an entrepreneur. It funds a vehicle, a roof, a journey, or a debt that is

never repaid — and then the program is declared a failure of character when it was in fact a failure of sequencing. The state should be far more willing to finance capability — technical training, cooperative management, storage, irrigation discipline, accounting, market access, the institutional machinery of risk and audit — than to finance expansion before that capability exists. Capability raises the probability that the next unit of capital is productive. Capital alone does not create capability.

This principle governs Simandou directly, because Simandou is the largest version of the same risk Guinea has already failed at a smaller scale. The danger of the Simandou era is not that Guinea will receive too little money. It is that Guinea will receive more capital than its institutions and its enterprises can absorb productively — and that the gap between the money and the capacity to use it will be filled, as it has been filled before, by extraction. The rule is therefore not that capital must wait for some perfect readiness that never arrives; capability is partly built by handling real money on real projects, and a state that accepted no investment until it was ready would learn nothing and build nothing. The rule is about rate. Capability must lead and capital must follow close behind it — never race so far ahead that the gap can only be filled by extraction. The failure Guinea has lived is not capital arriving slightly before readiness; it is capital arriving in floods against institutions that could absorb a trickle. And this is the deep reason that saving part of the windfall is not merely prudence but a structural necessity: holding revenue back is the throttle. Whatever the instrument, a state that keeps part of every windfall out of the economy in the year it arrives converts a flood it cannot absorb into a flow it can — releasing capital at the rate capability actually grows, rather than at the rate the ore happens to sell. Saving guards against the day the ore runs out; it also paces the days the ore pours in. The throttle is not a feature of any particular fund; it is what any honest restraint on spending does, and it is why restraint and capability must be built together — throttle the capital to what capability can convert,

and the two rise together, which is the whole of the Absorption Principle in practice.

The government appears richer. The state does not become stronger.

Part VII: The Capability-Dependency Trap

Capital that arrives before capability does not create it — it rents it. A nation that rents its abilities is renting its future back from those who own them.

The State Capacity Trap has a more dangerous long-term expression: the Capability-Dependency Trap. Picture a power plant that rises on schedule, financed from abroad and built by a foreign firm. The ribbon is cut, the lights come on. Years later a turbine fails, and there is no Guinean who can repair it; the same firm is flown back at the same cost, because the first contract built the plant but left behind no one who could run it. The building was real. The capability was rented. This is not a story about one power plant. It is the shape of a trap, and the cycle operates as follows.

The state lacks engineers, project managers, procurement specialists, and technical regulators. Because it lacks capacity, it outsources to foreign firms. Foreign firms build and manage the infrastructure. Foreign firms train too few local replacements because full knowledge transfer reduces their future value. Domestic capability grows slowly. The next generation of projects again requires foreign execution. The dependency becomes structural.

A successful state uses foreign expertise as a bridge. An unsuccessful state uses foreign expertise as a substitute.

This is how countries receive billions of dollars of investment across decades and still find themselves unable to execute projects

independently. The investment was real. The capability transfer was not.

The Capability Rule

Every major project must leave behind more Guinean capability than existed before the project began. Not more concrete. Not more equipment. More capability. Measurably more — in the form of trained engineers, qualified managers, certified technicians, experienced regulators, and capable procurement officers who remain in Guinea after the project concludes.

Capability compounds. A country that builds capability in year one is dramatically more capable in year ten. A country that substitutes foreign execution for domestic capability in year one is no more capable in year ten. The difference between these two trajectories is the difference between transformation and permanent dependency.

The Learning Standard

This points to the quiet engine beneath the entire doctrine. States do not become wealthy primarily by accumulating roads, mines, or revenue. They become wealthy by learning — by converting each project into transferable knowledge that makes the next project cheaper, faster, and better executed. Capability is the stock. Learning is the flow that builds it. A state that executes a hundred projects and learns nothing is no stronger than when it began; a state that executes ten and learns from each becomes formidable.

Every major undertaking must therefore be required to produce more than its physical output. It must produce lessons that are recorded, data that is retained, capability that remains, and institutional memory that survives the officials who happened to oversee it. A road must leave behind engineers who can build the next road. A mining agreement must leave behind negotiators who drive a harder

bargain next time. An agricultural program must leave behind the knowledge of why it succeeded or failed, held by an institution rather than scattered among individuals who move on. This is what connects Simandou, agriculture, the corridors, foreign capital, and technical education into a single objective: each is not only a thing to be built but a chance for the state to become more capable of building. Treated this way, Simandou is the largest learning opportunity in Guinea's history. Treated the way Guinea has treated its past windfalls, it will be the largest forgotten one.

A successful state uses foreign expertise as a bridge. An unsuccessful state uses it as a substitute.

Part VIII: The Enforcement Problem

Guinea has already written nearly every law this doctrine asks for. The law exists; it simply does not govern. Everything turns on that gap.

The Law Already Exists

Nearly every rule this doctrine asks for is already law in Guinea. This must be said plainly, because it changes what the work actually is. The country does not lack laws that promise impartial courts, equal treatment, secure property, an honest count, an army subject to civil authority, and an administration that serves the public rather than itself. Those promises are already on the page, written by Guineans, declared in the most formal terms the state possesses. A citizen already has, in law, the right to have his case heard by an independent court and to sue the State itself or any powerful person and win if he is right. Land is already, in law, protected as property. The vote is already, in law, secret and its true count guaranteed. The armed forces are already, in law, apolitical and forbidden from turning their power to private ends. Favoritism by ethnicity, region, or clan is already, in law, a punishable offense. None of this needs to be invented. All of it has already been promised.

And almost none of it governs daily life. This is the whole of the matter. The distance between what the law says and what actually happens is not a detail of Guinean governance; it is the disease itself,

named in the country's own statutes. The law is the formal map. The access economy is the real map. (Political economists call the second arrangement a limited-access order — a society that holds itself stable by rationing wealth and opportunity to a connected few; this doctrine, having watched it from inside, simply calls it the access economy and sets out to end it.) And in no institution do the two maps diverge more completely, or more consequentially, than in the one whose entire purpose is to make the law real: the courts. A right that exists on paper and dies in practice is not a milder version of a right. It is its absence, dressed in the language of its presence — which is worse, because it lets the state insist that the citizen already has what he plainly does not.

The Keystone

Impartial enforcement is not one institution among the many this doctrine describes. It is the one that determines whether any of the others mean anything. Every rule in these pages — the Resource Constitution, the land registry, the separation of armed power, the prohibitions, the reformer's own self-binding — is only as real as the courtroom that will enforce it against someone powerful. A law that will not be enforced impartially is not a law; it is a suggestion that the strong may take or leave. A registry whose titles a judge will not uphold against a minister's son is paper. A contract that the right party cannot win in court is not a contract; it is a hope. Build every institution in this doctrine, and if the courts answer to power rather than to law, you have built nothing — because power will simply route around all of it through the one institution that was supposed to stop it.

Consider what changes the day enforcement becomes real, because the whole productive economy turns on it. When two entrepreneurs fall into dispute and both know the tribunal will rule for the one who is in the right — not the one with access — then contracts become

worth signing, credit becomes worth extending, and a stranger becomes worth doing business with. When two parties contest a parcel and both know the registry holder will keep the land even when the other is the cousin of a general, then the title is finally worth having and the land becomes capital. When an ordinary person knows he can sue a company and be made whole, the powerful become accountable to the weak — the exact inversion of the access economy. When an investor knows a regulator's decision against a connected firm will hold, he commits capital he would otherwise keep abroad. None of this requires new law. It requires that the law already written be obeyed when it rules against the powerful.

Why the Law Sleeps

If the laws are good and yet do not govern, the honest question is why — and the answer is not that the right statute has not yet been found. The courtroom is the single point where the access economy is supposed to be stopped, and in a captured state it is instead the point where capture is ratified. The judge who rules by connection rather than by right is not failing to apply the doctrine's first principle; he is the access economy in its most concentrated form, sitting precisely where it was meant to be defeated. When the enforcer is captured, capture becomes law. This is why writing more law changes nothing: the problem was never the text, and a reformer who responds to a sleeping law by drafting a better one has misunderstood the disease. The law sleeps because waking it would cost powerful people the impunity they currently enjoy, and they defend that impunity exactly as they defend any other source of wealth.

So the demand this doctrine makes is not that Guinea write a justice system — it has one, on paper — but that it make the existing law bind, which is not a drafting problem but a power problem. A judge rules impartially only when ruling impartially is safer than ruling for the powerful: when the institution behind him shields him from the

general whose son he ruled against, when his career and his safety do not depend on the network's favor, when a decision against power holds instead of being undone by a phone call. The impartial court is not written into being; it is defended into being. It requires precisely the self-binding this doctrine asks of the powerful everywhere else — those who hold power must build courts that can rule against them, and then obey the ruling. This is the same act named as the one unfakeable proof of a genuine reformer, and it is run, or failed, in every courtroom in the country every day. Until a judge can rule for the registry holder against the minister's son and have that ruling stand, every other institution in this doctrine is paper — and the country already has the paper.

The Count and the Question of Belonging

The same gap runs through the way power itself is won. The law already promises a vote that is secret and a count that is true; the failure is in the practice, and a great deal follows from it. When people do not trust that the count will be honored, politics stops being a contest over how to govern and becomes a contest to capture the machinery that does the counting — which is only the access economy in electoral form, the prize being the state itself. And here the doctrine must name something Guinea knows and rarely says plainly: where institutions are not trusted to protect people impartially, people fall back on the one protection they do trust, which is their own group. Voting along ethnic lines, in such a country, is not primarily bigotry. It is a rational response to institutional weakness. If the state will not reliably protect you regardless of who you are, you rationally prefer that someone who is yours holds power, because your group is the only enforcement mechanism you actually believe in. Political scientists studying divided societies reached the same conclusion from the other direction: where institutions are impartial, ethnic loyalty fades as a basis for politics; where they are not, it is the rational

insurance a citizen falls back on. The doctrine did not borrow this; it watched it, and the scholarship confirms what the watching showed.

This reframes the cure, and the doctrine holds to its own logic in naming it. You do not talk a people out of protecting themselves; you make the protection unnecessary. As impartial institutions become real — above all the impartial court and the trustworthy count — the rational basis for ethnic fallback weakens, because a citizen no longer needs his own group to hold power in order to be safe under a law that finally applies to everyone. The cure for ethnic political mobilization is not exhortation against it, which insults people for responding sanely to the world as it is. The cure is the impartial state, which changes the world they are responding to.

But the doctrine must be honest about a circularity here, because it is the same one that runs beneath the whole work. The impartial state is the cure for ethnic fallback — yet building that state requires the very thing the fallback prevents. A trustworthy count and a court that binds the powerful cannot be built while politics is still a contest for group survival, because the group that holds power will not consent to machinery that ends its protection, and the group that does not hold it will not trust that machinery until it has already proven itself. The cure, in other words, requires a measure of the cure to exist before it can be built. This is not a flaw peculiar to the ethnic question; it is the doctrine's central fragility appearing in one more place — the same gap between an institutional destination and a transition that runs, at the start, through the choices of people inside the broken system. The doctrine does not dissolve this loop here, any more than it dissolved it in the Guardianship Trap. It names it, because a cure that hid its own precondition would be exactly the kind of false resolution this doctrine exists to refuse.

But naming a barrier is not the same as abandoning the reader before it, and the doctrine owes the reformer who stands at this one an account of what is at stake and what to carry into it. What is at stake is the largest prize and the largest danger the country holds at once:

handled well, the slow construction of impartial institutions drains the ethnic contest of its rational fuel and a divided nation becomes a governable one; handled badly, the same reforms are read by each group as a move by some other group to disarm it, and the attempt to build the neutral state becomes the spark that hardens the very division it meant to dissolve. The barrier is dangerous precisely because the cure and the catastrophe travel the same road, and for a time look alike.

So the reformer cannot wait for the loop to open on its own, and cannot force it shut by will; what he can do is hold a few things in mind that decide which way it breaks. That trust is built where it can be checked, not where it must be taken on faith — which is why a single verifiable thing, a count every group can watch and confirm for itself, does more than any assurance. That the order of moves matters more than their speed: a neutral institution demonstrated to work once, visibly, for everyone, makes the next one easier to trust, while a reform imposed before it can be believed makes all the rest harder. That no group will surrender its self-protection until it has seen, not been promised, that the impartial state will protect it instead — so the early proofs must be real, public, and indifferent to whose side they help. And that the reformer's own neutrality is itself one of those proofs, watched more closely than he knows: the first group to suspect the neutral state is a mask for someone else's advantage will reach back for its own protection, and pull the others after it. None of this opens the loop by formula. It tells the reformer what the loop is made of, so that he works with its grain instead of being surprised by it — which is the most the doctrine can honestly offer, and more than silence would.

And this doctrine refuses, deliberately, to tell anyone which group to support or to favor — because to do so would be to play the very game it exists to end. Its neutrality is not an evasion. It is part of the cure: a doctrine that any leader of any origin can carry is itself a small

proof that belonging to the right group is not the thing that should determine who may govern well.

The justice system, then, is where this doctrine is ultimately won or lost. Not because Guinea must write new rules, but because the rules it has already written must finally bind the people they were written to bind. Everything else — the corridors, the Resource Constitution, the registry, the separation of the army — rests on this one institution doing, in practice, what the law already says it must do in principle. That is the enforcement problem, and it is the quietest and most decisive of all the problems this doctrine names.

Part IX: The Land Question

The most widely held asset in Guinea is the one almost no one can prove they hold — and wealth that cannot be proven is wealth lying dead in the ground.

A farmer in the Fouta, a family in Haute Guinée, a household near Boké, a village holding ground passed down since a great-grandparent's time — all of them possess land, and almost none of them can prove it in a way the state will reliably defend. This is not a regional problem confined to one corner of the country. It is a national institutional failure, and it sits directly on the doctrine's central nerve: an asset that cannot be documented, defended, or borrowed against is dead capital — the term is Hernando de Soto's, who described the same buried wealth across the developing world; in Guinea it lies in the untitled fields of the Fouta as surely as anywhere — and a country whose people cannot secure the ground beneath them cannot build a productive economy on top of it.

Two Failures, One Cause

The failure takes two forms. The first is documentation. Across rural Guinea, land is held by inheritance and custom — known locally, passed through generations, never formalized — and only a tiny fraction of it carries any formal title at all. The overwhelming majority of the country's land is, from the state's point of view, invisible. It cannot be used as collateral, cannot be confidently invested in, cannot

become the foundation of an enterprise. A bank asked to lend against it has no title to register and no basis to value, so it lends against a salaried employment contract instead — which the informal majority do not have. The single most valuable thing most Guinean families own is locked out of the productive economy entirely, and with it locked out, so is almost everyone who is not already inside the formal salaried world.

The second failure is that even documentation does not protect. Because there is no unified, authoritative registry against which a claim can be checked, the same parcel can be sold to two, three, or four different buyers, each walking away with papers that look valid, the fraud surfacing only later in court. Title in Guinea too often does not prove ownership. Possession is settled not by right but by occupation — by who builds on the land fast enough to hold it — which is a primitive and violent way to run a property system, and a catastrophic one for an economy that needs people to invest before they build. The courts are now buried under many thousands of disputed land files, and conflicts over the same ground have produced not only ruin but death.

Both failures have one cause: Guinea has no trustworthy, unified, verifiable record of who owns what. The state has recognized this and begun, in recent years, to move toward secured and digitized titles. That start must become a national system carried through to completion — not a pilot in the capital, but the foundation of property for the whole country.

What land governance must satisfy

A productive state requires that ground be secure before almost anything else. What that security requires is not a particular agency or system — Guinea can build those in many forms — but a set of conditions that must hold however they are built, and each is a principle, not a blueprint.

There must be one authoritative record of who owns what, against which any claim can be checked, so that a single parcel carries a single valid title and the same ground cannot be sold three times over. Without one trustworthy record, every paper issued is only another sheet in a future court file.

Documentation must be something an ordinary Guinean — in a city or a village — can actually obtain, or it ceases to be protection and becomes privilege. A process too slow, too costly, or too opaque to use is not security; it is exclusion dressed as procedure.

Customary and inherited holdings must be recognized, not erased — the rural majority who hold land without paper brought into the system as owners, not dispossessed by a formalization that recognizes only those who arrive first with lawyers. A record must document what exists, not redistribute it to whoever files fastest.

Compensation, wherever land is taken, must be decided by no party that profits from the taking. What is paid must be set by someone legally separate from the project and answerable to the people displaced, because compensation decided by those who benefit from the displacement is not compensation — it is dispossession with paperwork.

And disputes must be settled by a forum that binds all sides and serves none. Land conflict cannot be resolved by the state alone, which lacks legitimacy with those who hold by custom; nor by custom alone, which cannot bind an investor; nor by the investor, who earns no trust at all. The institutional form matters less than the principle it must satisfy — the oldest principle in the law of fair judgment, that no one should be a judge in his own cause, and that no settled claim depends on the goodwill of the powerful. This matters most wherever new value lands on contested ground, because rising value over unclear rights does not produce prosperity; it produces the kind of conflict that halts development for a generation.

From these follows one bright line. Where a major concession or acquisition will take or sharply revalue land, the rules of ownership

and compensation must be real for that ground before the earth-moving begins — not as a schedule or a date, but as a condition. A state that lets the work start before ownership is secure has chosen, knowingly, the sequence that produces dispossession and conflict. Secure the ground, then move the money — never the reverse.

Secure title is not paperwork. It is the conversion of dead capital into productive capital. A farmer who can prove and borrow against his field can invest in it. A woman who can title the land she works can build an enterprise from it. A family whose generational holding becomes a recognized asset gains, for the first time, something to build on rather than merely something to defend.

But title is necessary, not sufficient. A registry only releases this capital if the banks will accept newly documented rural land as collateral and can value it — which they will not do on their own — and if credit itself is redesigned for an economy where most people hold no salaried contract: collateral frameworks suited to rural property, lending models that do not assume a payslip, and the institutional capacity, on both sides, to assess a borrower no formal record describes. The state must build the registry and work with the banks to make what it documents usable. Here too, capability must precede capital: papers without a credit system able to read them release nothing.

This is National Rule Zero written into the soil: when ownership is secure, value flows to those who produce; when ownership is insecure, value flows to those with the connections and the speed to manipulate claims.

And this is the point at which the registry rejoins the keystone, because a registry is not self-executing and is captured the same way a court is. Whoever administers the first registration can be reached by the powerful, and a register that records the claims of the connected ahead of the people who have worked the land for generations does not end the old injustice; it gives it a clean title and makes it permanent. The registry is therefore only as honest as the enforcement

behind it — as the judge who will uphold the smallholder's entry against the minister's son, and the authority that will correct a fraudulent registration instead of ratifying it. Without that, the registry becomes one more institution the access economy captures at the moment of its creation, and the most documented claims become the best-defended thefts. The land chapter does not escape the enforcement problem. It depends on its solution.

Compensation decided by those who profit from displacement is not compensation. It is dispossession with paperwork.

Part X: The Foreign Capital Doctrine

Foreign capital is neither rescue nor robbery. It is a tool, and a tool decides nothing — the strength of the hand that holds it decides everything.

The debate over foreign investment is usually framed as a binary: exploitation or development, robbery or rescue. Both framings are analytically empty, because they locate the outcome in the capital itself rather than in the state that receives it. The same investment that hollows out one country builds another. What differs is not the money but the hand that takes it. The real question is therefore never whether Guinea should accept foreign capital. It should, and it must. The real question is: does Guinea become more capable after each major investment than it was before?

The Learning Standard

The objective of Guinea's foreign capital doctrine is not to maximize royalty rates in year one. It is to maximize national capability over a decade: technology transfer, managerial knowledge, engineering expertise, regulatory competence, negotiation sophistication, industrial learning.

A successful deal is not one that extracts the highest payment this year. It is one that leaves Guinea better able to negotiate, build, manage, and compete ten years later.

Guinea's mining sector has been financed by a shifting cast of external actors, and the doctrine deliberately refuses to organize itself around any one of them. The multilateral institutions and Western capital have long been among the largest forces; large flows from Asia arrived more recently; the Simandou development itself is split between partners of different nationalities rather than held by any single country. A decade from now the largest investor may be one barely present today. This is precisely why the doctrine fixes on the principle and not the player: the identity of the foreign investor is a fact of the moment, not a feature of the problem. Existing contractual commitments, from whatever source, create constraints that must be acknowledged honestly. The challenge is never resisting capital from a particular country — it is ensuring that foreign capital of any origin builds Guinean capability rather than substituting for it, and leaves more behind than it takes out.

A weak state negotiates from desperation and accepts dependency as the price. A capable state negotiates from competence and uses external capital as a bridge to self-sufficiency. Guinea's foreign capital doctrine has one objective: become the capable state.

There is a dimension of this that the language of partnership tends to hide, and the doctrine states it plainly because Guinea has already paid for the silence. The same weakness that lets a domestic network capture the state also lets foreign actors acquire a nation's resources for less than they are worth — because a fair price is enforced by a strong state, and where the state is weak there is nothing to enforce it. The under-collection is not a series of unlucky deals. It is what the absence of a strong state produces by default: a continuous transfer of wealth out of the country, into the margins of those who buy cheap what a stronger Guinea would have made them pay for. The bauxite decades are the proof already written — vast export, little revenue, the difference captured partly at home and partly abroad. This is not an accusation of villainy. The foreign buyer who pays as little as the system permits is behaving exactly as the domestic rent-seeker does:

rationally, in response to what a weak state allows. Naming it is not grievance. It is the precondition for ending it.

And here is the trap, parallel to the domestic one and tightened by it: the only thing that can stop an unfair transfer abroad is a stronger state, and a stronger state is precisely what the beneficiaries of the transfer are incentivized to prevent. A president who builds real capacity in the mining sector — who asserts a fair price, who makes the contracts public, who taxes what was untaxed, who insists that capability be left behind — is not only confronting the domestic network. He is reducing the margins of powerful external actors, and they can answer in ways no domestic faction can: capital that withdraws, financing that dries up, contracts dragged into international arbitration, diplomatic pressure, the credit rating and the investment climate turned into instruments, and the quiet alignment of foreign interest with the reformer's domestic enemies, who now find powerful friends abroad. The domestic coalition and the foreign one are not separate fights; they discover each other, because they are enriched by the same weakness and threatened by the same strength.

The doctrine offers no clean escape from this, because there is none, but it does offer the one fact that keeps the trap from being hopeless: the external resistance is not invincible, and a state that builds even partial capacity can claw back some of what a weak state surrenders. The proof is concrete and recent. When Guinea set a reference price for bauxite and required that exports be valued against it, the state asserted, in one stroke, a floor beneath which the transfer could not legally fall — and made visible, and chargeable, a margin that had simply been leaving the country. That is not the whole answer. It is evidence that the answer exists: that capability, asserted from a position of competence rather than desperation, can recover value that weakness was giving away, and that the foreign beneficiary who fights a weak state will deal with a strong one because the resource is still worth having on fairer terms. The bridge from desperation to competence is the same bridge described throughout

this doctrine, and it is the only road out of the transfer. How far and how fast it can be crossed against determined resistance is, again, a governing question — answered not by analysis but by the leverage, the alliances, and the resolve available to those who hold power. But the doctrine owes the reformer who faces this two things to carry into it. The first is that the foreign resistance and the domestic one are a single coalition, not two: they are enriched by the same weakness and threatened by the same strength, so the strength that weakens the one weakens the other, and the fight is on one front rather than two. The second is that partial victory is real victory here, and the foreign actor's most frightening threat — to withdraw its capital and leave — is rarely as total as it sounds, because the ore remains in the ground and remains worth having. A buyer who walks away from a fair price walks away from the resource itself; which is why the capable state discovers that the leverage runs in both directions, and why a defensible gain banked now — a reference price, a published contract, a tax that holds — is worth more than a total victory held out for and lost. Each increment that holds makes the next one easier to take. None of this guarantees the crossing; it tells the reformer what the river is made of.

A fair price is enforced by a strong state, or it is not enforced at all. What weakness gives away, only capability takes back.

Part XI: The Guardianship Trap

Many nations have civilian governments; far fewer have civilian states. The structures are easy to build, and Guinea has built them well — even on paper, the principles are sound. The question is who actually holds the power inside them, against whom that power is turned, and what that power is used to protect. For the thing this chapter describes is not a government but an arrangement: political authority, the command of force, and economic privilege fused into a single structure, each guarding the others. That fusion is the subject of this chapter, and the deepest institutional obstacle a productive republic must overcome.

The State, the Military, and the Question of Power

What the Republic Already Promises

A doctrine must describe reality as it is, not as it is officially presented, and not as anyone wishes it to be. But it must begin by giving the Republic credit for what it has already declared, because the gap between that declaration and the practice is the whole of the matter. Guinea's own Constitution states the principle this chapter exists to defend, and states it well. It defines the forces of defense and security as republican and apolitical, in the service of the Nation and subject to the legally established civilian authority, bound to carry out their missions in respect for human rights — and it forbids, in the plainest terms, that anyone divert them to private ends. It gives them a

defining mission — the protection of the nation and its people, the defense of its territory, the maintenance of public order under the law — never the choosing of who governs. It requires the public administration to stand in the exclusive service of the population, neutral and impartial, and it makes favoritism by ethnicity, clan, region, or religion a punishable offense. These are not foreign standards imported by this doctrine. They are the Republic's own commitments, written in its founding law.

The central institutional challenge of Guinea, therefore, has not been the absence of the right principle. It has been the repeated failure to make that principle the operating reality of the state. A constitutional republic is not defined by holding elections, nor by writing the correct words into its charter. It is defined by whether every institution that exercises coercive or administrative power actually remains neutral and serves the Nation rather than those who temporarily govern it. The work before the Republic is to make the constitutional promise the lived practice of the state — and the distance between the two is exactly what this chapter describes.

Governments and States

Guinea's history is often described as alternating between civilian and military governments. Formally this is true; analytically it misses the continuity that has survived every change of face at the top. Since independence, power has passed between civilian and military leaders, through elections, succession, and force. Yet beneath every change one pattern has held. The question has rarely been whether the person at the top wore a suit or a uniform. It has been whether the institutions entrusted with protecting the republic served the republic — or served whoever happened to hold power within it. And across every era the answer has too often been the same. The army, the police, and the security services have been turned inward: used not to defend the constitutional order but to defend those who governed it, against the

citizens who challenged their authority — opponents, demonstrators, journalists, critics, and at the extreme those made to disappear for refusing to be silenced. The force the Constitution charges with protecting the nation and its people was spent, regime after regime, on protecting power from the people. Sometimes the hand that wielded it wore a uniform; sometimes civilian clothes and the same instruments. The faces changed; the function of force beneath them did not.

And this continuity has never been only political — and here is the pattern on which the whole chapter turns. Coercive power and political authority rarely stand alone; they attach themselves to wealth. Access to contracts, licenses, procurement, customs, land, and mining concessions comes to depend on proximity to the same network that commands the instruments of force. Political authority shields economic privilege, economic privilege funds political authority, and coercion protects them both. What results is not merely a concentration of political power but a single integrated arrangement — political, coercive, and economic — and the network that holds it is not purely military. It binds officers and civilians, those in office and those merely close to it, into one structure that has proven more durable than any government that has sat atop it. This is the fusion. Everything that follows in this chapter — the two maps, the builder and the tyrant, the confiscation, the self-binding — exists to explain how this arrangement conceals itself, why it resists dismantling, and how, if ever, it is undone.

This is why Guinea is not well described by the classical model of military rule, where an army governs as an institution and runs the commercial empire it openly owns. Guinea's pattern is more fluid and, in its way, harder to dislodge. The distinction that matters is not between civilian and military government. It is between a constitutional republic, in which the institutions of force answer to the law and protect every citizen regardless of who governs, and a captured republic, in which those same institutions become the means by which whoever governs holds his power and guards the wealth attached to it.

The doctrine therefore begins not with who governs but with the question beneath it: who commands the means of coercion, in whose service, and toward whom are they pointed?

Formal Power and Real Power

Every state can be described by two maps that are supposed to be identical and often are not. The first is the formal map: the constitution, the ministries, the assembly, the courts, the elected offices, the official chain of command — legitimate power, named and accountable. The second is the real map: the network of relationships that actually decides who is appointed, which contracts are signed, which licenses are granted, and where force is directed.

When the two maps coincide, the state can be reformed, because reforming the institution reforms the power. When the real map sits outside or above the formal one, institutional reform becomes theater: a government can rewrite every procurement rule in the country and change nothing, because the rules were never where the decisions lived. This is the deeper sense in which Guinea's challenge is not constitutional design but enforcement — the formal map already says the right things; the real map ignores them. This is how the fusion conceals itself: it keeps the published state intact as a façade while the real decisions are made off the map.

This is the Guardianship Trap. In its starkest form the uniform governs openly; but it does not require that, and its more durable form is quieter. Elections occur. Parliaments sit. Ministers govern. Courts issue rulings. And yet the decisions that matter are shaped by relationships outside ordinary institutional competition, and the instruments of force remain available to whoever holds power, pointed at whoever would challenge it. Other nations have lived their own versions of power that sits somewhere other than where the constitution says; the particular form in Guinea is its own — not an army that rules as an institution, but a network, military and civilian at once, that

holds power by controlling the means of coercion and turns them on the governed to keep it.

Institutional Fusion

In such a configuration a single network holds what a functioning republic deliberately separates: political authority, economic authority, security authority, and increasingly constitutional authority as well. These powers fuse precisely because they are held informally, outside the institutional walls meant to keep them apart. The constitution that should constrain power is used to formalize it; the economy that should reward production rewards proximity; the security apparatus that should protect the republic protects the arrangement.

The relationship between coercion and the rest deserves naming directly, because it is how the fusion works in Guinea. In some states the army builds a commercial empire — owning companies, running ports and customs as businesses. Guinea is not yet that state, and the distinction matters: here the capture runs not mainly through ownership but through force, and the force is turned first of all upon the people. Its primary use is the suppression of citizens — the power to arrest those who oppose a law, break up a demonstration, jail an opponent, silence a journalist, and at the worst make those who challenge power disappear — to raise the cost of dissent until the governed stop trying to remove those who govern them. The same instrument turns to profit: the monopoly on force becomes the power to decide who operates in the mining zones and who is shut out, to protect a favored route, to detain whoever stands in the way of the network's wealth, to make courts and police serve money as readily as power. Force keeps the people from removing those in power; force keeps the rewards flowing to the network around them. The holder of that power need not own the port if he can decide who passes through it, and need not answer to the citizen if he can imprison the citizen who asks. The fully owned commercial empire is not Guinea's present

condition but the destination toward which an entrenched coercive network drifts: the longer a single network holds the instruments of force, the more its hold on the economy hardens from informal extraction into open ownership. Time is the danger.

That mutual protection is not permanent, and this should concentrate the mind of everyone inside the arrangement as much as everyone outside it. Political power can be lost while economic entrenchment remains, leaving a captured economy behind whatever government inherits the formal offices. Informal power feels more secure than institutional power; it is in fact less secure, because it depends on the network remaining intact, and when the network fractures — as networks eventually do — there is no institution left to fall back on.

The same gap between formal authority and real power runs inside the security forces themselves, and this is the clearest proof of how deep the pattern goes. An army has a formal map of its own — ranks, a chain of command, a general who outranks a lieutenant. But where a network holds power through force, it builds a real map over that formal one. A favored inner core — the unit whose loyalty secures those at the top — receives the pay, the equipment, and the standing, while the regular army is left under-resourced and weak.

Soldiers come to be rewarded by loyalty to the network rather than by rank or mission, and once that happens the formal hierarchy is already hollow: a junior man from the favored core can defy a senior officer outside it, because real authority follows the network, not the insignia. A weak, impoverished regular army beside a privileged inner guard is not disorder; it is the network reproduced in uniform, the two-map problem written into the institution that holds the guns. And the network is not civilians wielding a neutral army, nor soldiers acting apart from civilians: officers of the army and police are themselves among its principals, taking their share through their command of force, alongside the civilians the arrangement serves and who serve it.

The Legitimacy Trap

States can survive long periods on control; prosperous nations require legitimacy. Control compels obedience; legitimacy generates cooperation. The difference is economic before it is moral. Investors commit capital, entrepreneurs expand, farmers invest in next year's harvest, and skilled citizens choose to stay only when they believe the rules will outlast the people who currently enforce them. When real power sits outside the institutions, none of them can plan, because the published contract, license, and law are not the real ones — the real decision is made by someone whose name is not on the document. When proximity to the network matters more than any formal right, the entire productive economy is subordinated to the political-security network, and access becomes not merely more rewarding than production but a precondition for it. National Rule Zero is violated at the root — and it is the fusion that violates it.

The Cycle

Guinea's modern history has repeated one pattern with remarkable consistency. Power becomes concentrated. The instruments of force are turned to holding it. Institutions remain subordinate to whoever holds power. Justice becomes selective. Opportunity becomes a political favor. Legitimacy erodes. A crisis arrives. New leadership emerges promising to break with the past — and inherits the same incentives, the same concentration, the same subordinate institutions, the same coercive instruments waiting to be used. The names change. The structure does not.

This doctrine therefore rejects the idea that development depends on the character of leaders. No society can afford to depend on the virtue of those who happen to hold power, because power changes hands and virtue is not heritable. A productive state is built not by good leaders but by institutions strong enough to constrain bad ones — and strong enough to constrain good ones who would otherwise be

tempted, as every holder of unchecked power eventually is. Strong institutions survive changes in leadership; weak institutions become extensions of whoever leads.

Civilianization and the Veil of Ignorance

The objective is not confrontation between institutions — confrontation produces instability, instability destroys investment, and investment is what the productive economy requires. The objective is civilianization: the deliberate migration of real power into the formal institutions, so that legitimate and real power become the same thing. Economic governance comes to be ruled by rules rather than relationships. Customs becomes professional rather than political; procurement competitive rather than discretionary; ports commercially managed rather than patronage-managed; mining regulation technical rather than personal; state enterprises performance institutions rather than political instruments; resource revenues subject to rules stronger than any officeholder.

The principle that makes this acceptable even to those who benefit from the fusion is a simple test: institutions should be designed as if those creating them do not know whether they will govern or be governed under them. A system built only to protect today's holders of power will be turned against them, because today's winner is tomorrow's loser — and Guinea's own recent history offers proof enough that those who build an unaccountable system are frequently destroyed by the absence of the protections they denied to others.

The separation of power is not a concession the strong make to the weak. It is the insurance the strong would buy if they were wise enough to know their position is temporary. But wisdom is not the binding constraint, and the doctrine must be honest about why separation does not happen on its own. The deepest obstacle is not that the powerful fail to see the logic. It is that no one can afford to move first. Where political, economic, and security power are fused and

protect one another, the actor who relinquishes his share before the others relinquish theirs does not become a statesman; he becomes a target.

Each would accept separation if all the others accepted it at the same moment — and each knows that to disarm alone, while the rest remain armed, is to be consumed. This is why the fusion survives even when everyone inside it can see the country, and eventually they themselves, would be safer without it. Separation is not principally a problem of persuasion.

It is a problem of simultaneous and credible mutual commitment — the hardest thing a divided elite can achieve. But naming it as hard is not leaving it unanswered, because the structure of the bind points to the way out. A demand that everyone disarm at once, on trust, will never be met. What can be met is a sequence of verifiable, hard-to-reverse steps, each expensive to fake: one agrees to a binding audit mechanism before any audit runs; another places his future appointments, not yet made, inside a rule he will no longer control; a third lets a court rule against him in a contained matter and obeys. Each step must be structured so that the early ones cost little to take but much to betray. And what makes a dangerous first move survivable is a third thing strong enough to hold the ring — to raise the cost to whoever would exploit the one who moved first. With the ring held, each surviving step makes the next safer, and trust accumulates in increments rather than being demanded in a single leap. This is the founder's self-binding turned from a solitary act into a collective one: no one disarms alone and unprotected; each disarms a little, under a guarantee, in a sequence where defection is visible and punished.

But the doctrine must be as honest about the ring-holder as it is about the founder, because the same diagnosis that demands one casts doubt on every candidate to be it. The court that might hold the ring is, by this chapter's own account, often captured. The other powers that might hold it are co-principals in the fusion, with their own shares to protect. An external guarantor can hold a ring no domestic body can

— but it does so at a cost to sovereignty the rest of this doctrine is built to refuse, and a guarantor that can hold the ring today can pull it tomorrow. So the ring-holder is named here as the second thing this doctrine requires and cannot manufacture. The founder must supply the will to move first; some institution credible enough to make moving first survivable must already exist, or be built early, before the sequence can begin. Where that ring-holder is to come from in a fully captured state — a court not yet free, a constitutional moment not yet arrived, a balance of powers not yet bound — is a question this doctrine can pose sharply but cannot answer in the abstract. It is the first thing a serious reformer must locate or create, because without it the verifiable sequence has no floor to stand on, and the first mover has no protection but luck.

Who Can Carry This

There is a temptation to believe that only a clean outsider — someone untouched by the network, owing it nothing — can carry out what this doctrine describes. That belief is a trap of its own. It tells the country to wait for a savior who may never come, and it tells everyone already inside the system that their case is closed, that having benefited from the arrangement they are disqualified from improving it. Both conclusions are false, and the second is the more corrosive, because it excuses the people best positioned to act.

An outsider can come to power and succeed; nothing here denies it. But an outsider can also take office carrying every hope of those who wanted the system broken and be absorbed by it, leaving it stronger than before — because power in a captured state runs through the network, and whoever would govern must reach for the network to govern at all, and reaching for it is how it takes hold of them. Cleanliness does not survive contact with the office on its own. The outsider is not a guarantee, and the insider is not a disqualification.

This doctrine does not ask who you have been. A minister who has grown rich on the arrangement, a director who has handed contracts to her own, a commander who has taken his share, an official absorbed by the system for decades — none is foreclosed. Any one of them can reach a moment and decide: I have taken enough; now I will use what position and knowledge and leverage I have to build something that serves the people, and not only me.

That decision is available to anyone who holds a position and the will to turn it, woman or man, at any time. The system endures in part because the people most able to change it have persuaded themselves that they cannot — that their hands are too dirty, that they may as well keep taking. The doctrine names that for what it is: the most useful lie the arrangement tells, and the first thing a reformer discards.

But the door opens only one way. The doctrine welcomes the compromised; it does not excuse them. Past benefit is not the test — if it were, no one would be left to act. The test is what comes after the turn, and the proof of a genuine turn is not words but power surrendered, by the measure the sections that follow set out. The official who declares good intentions while preserving every instrument of his discretion has not turned; he has learned the language. The doctrine offers the door to anyone, and reserves its trust for those who walk through it and lock it behind themselves.

The Reformer's Vise

Whoever attempts this, from inside or out, is caught in a vise the doctrine should describe rather than wish away. It has three jaws, and they close together. The first is the gap between legitimacy and capability: the system is built so that the standing the people grant and the power the network commands rarely sit in the same person. The outsider the people trust often cannot command the machine; the insider who commands it is often distrusted. The reformer's first task is to assemble both in one place — to borrow legitimacy if he comes

with power, or power if he comes with legitimacy — and neither is freely given.

The second jaw is speed: reform imposes its costs at once and delivers its benefits slowly, and between the two lies a valley in which the network turns on the reformer fast while popular support arrives late. The third jaw is the order in which enemies are made: move against the wrong faction before you can survive its enmity and you have made an enemy that ends you. How a reformer crosses the valley and sequences his enemies belongs to the doctrine's account of the first move and of political survival, and is not re-argued here. What belongs here is the warning that the three jaws close at once, and that whoever does not expect them has mistaken the nature of the struggle.

The Builder's Necessity and the Tyrant's Alibi

This is the most dangerous truth in the doctrine, because stated carelessly it becomes the excuse for everything the doctrine opposes; it must therefore be stated with care. A reformer cannot govern by the institutions he has not yet built. The clean service does not exist to administer his reform; the impartial court does not yet rule; the rules he means to live under are not written. In the building phase he may have to wield concentrated power, use the captured system he means to replace, and play the network's game on its own terms — to construct the alternative that will one day make such methods forbidden. States that built well have sometimes been built by leaders who, in the building, did things the finished state would never permit. The doctrine will not pretend otherwise; a reader who holds power knows it is true.

But here is the knife-edge, and the reformer must stand on it with his eyes open: this same necessity is the exact alibi of every tyrant who ever entrenched himself. Every strongman who fused power and never released it said the same words — temporary, necessary, for the people, only until the work is done. The concentration that is

genuinely scaffolding and the concentration that is simply the point are indistinguishable in the moment, by the actor's own account, because both speak the identical sentence. The road to permanent capture is paved with emergencies that were going to be temporary, and the reformer who tells himself he will release the power later is telling himself precisely what every man who never released it also told himself.

No rule can tell a man in the moment which kind he is, because the liar and the honest builder feel the same from within — and the difficulty runs deeper than any observer's eye. Method, word, and intention can all be counterfeited; the clever tyrant will even build real institutions, as camouflage and because some machinery genuinely serves his control, so that for years the two are indistinguishable by any test available to those living through them. It can be hidden even from the man in the chair: a reformer can begin in good faith, wield the hard methods believing he will lay them down, and be turned by the power he holds into the thing he meant to dismantle, with no single moment of betrayal to point to — the builder becoming the tyrant by degrees, himself the last to understand it. This is why no one's account of his own intentions can be trusted as proof, his own included.

If method, word, intention, and even self-knowledge can all be counterfeited or mistaken, then one thing alone cannot be faked all the way to the end, and the doctrine returns to it as the only proof that finally speaks. The builder uses his concentrated power to construct the institutions that will eventually bind him — a service that will one day refuse his order, a court that will one day rule against him, a registry that will one day hold his own family's claims to the same standard as a stranger's. He builds his own cage and walks into it. The tyrant builds only the throne. Economists have drawn the same line: the ruler with a lasting stake in his country behaves like one who owns it and invests in its growth, while the one who expects only a short season strips it bare — the bandit who settles against the bandit who

raids. History keeps the names of the few who held supreme power and then surrendered it — the Roman who took absolute command, won the war, and went back to his farm; the general who, having won a revolution and led its army, resigned his commission and later walked away from power a second time rather than become the king he could have been. Their countries remembered them precisely because the act is so rare. And there is a direction that reveals which is which over time: the builder's exceptional methods decline as the institutions rise, the scaffolding coming down as the structure stands; the tyrant's methods grow, because the concentration was never scaffolding at all. The test is not a snapshot — both look the same on any single day — but a trajectory: over years, is power moving out of the person and into the institutions, or accumulating in the person and hollowing them? Even the trajectory may arrive too late to guide the choice; it can deliver the verdict but not in time to change it. Which is why the self-binding institution matters more, not less, once the unknowability is admitted. A constraint the man will actually obey against his own interest is the single performance the throne-builder cannot complete, because to complete it is to cease being a throne-builder. It is not merely the best evidence of a genuine turn. It is the only evidence that cannot be performed in bad faith to the end.

Strong Men and Strong Institutions

It is often said that what a country like Guinea needs is not strong leaders but strong institutions. As a description of the destination this is correct, and the whole doctrine agrees: the goal is a state where rules outlast the people who hold office, where no individual is the system. But as an account of how a country arrives there, the saying is incomplete, and the part it omits matters most.

Institutions do not build themselves. They do not assemble from a blueprint because someone has understood their design. Every strong institution that ever existed was built by people — and at the

founding, before the institution exists to do the work, that means built by a strong individual with the will and the principle to construct something that will then bind and outlast him. The choice is not between strong men and strong institutions; the deepest institutions are founded by a strong individual who chooses to spend his strength building the thing that makes strong individuals unnecessary. That is the founding paradox, and the slogan hides it.

This is the central fragility of the whole doctrine, and it must be admitted rather than hidden. Its destination transcends the individual: a finished state where no person is the system. But its transition does not, and cannot. The journey from a captured state to a self-binding one runs, at the founding, through a person — through the judgment, the sequencing, the restraint, and above all the willingness to surrender power of one leader who could choose otherwise and is constrained by nothing but principle to choose this. A doctrine whose destination is institutional but whose first step is leader-dependent carries a contradiction it can only name. So it names it plainly: it asks the institutions to outlast the leader, while admitting they can only be born from a leader the doctrine cannot manufacture, guarantee, or replace.

But naming the limit is not surrendering to it. Design cannot manufacture the founder's first choice; what it can do is make that choice, once taken, expensive to reverse — and that is what separates a reform that survives its author from one that dies with him. A founder converts intention into durable commitment in three ways. He surrenders his own exemption first, before asking it of anyone else, because a rule the powerful obey only when convenient is a favor, not a rule. He builds institutions that will hold real power after him — a service that can refuse his successor's order, a court that can rule against the office he once held, a registry and a fund that answer to published rules rather than to whoever sits at the center — so that reneging later means fighting the machinery he created, at a cost he has deliberately made high. And he anchors the commitment where

reversal is visible and shameful: rules written before the money arrives, accounts opened to the public, audits no minister can quietly suspend. None of this guarantees the founder is genuine; it guarantees that if he is, his work does not depend on his staying in the room, and that if a successor tries to undo it, the undoing is slow, public, and contested rather than quiet and free.

But knowledge and will are not the binding constraint either, and this is the harder truth. Institutions are not weak because no one knows how to build them. They are weak because their weakness is profitable, and the people who profit from it are the most powerful actors in the system. A weak customs service is not an accident awaiting good design; it is the income of everyone who feeds on a weak customs service. A weak mining regime is not an oversight; it is the wealth of everyone, at home and abroad, who profits from the absence of a strong one. The weakness is built and maintained on purpose, because for those who capture its rents the weakness is not a problem — it is the asset.

It follows that building a strong institution is not, to the powerful, an act of construction. It is an act of confiscation. To build a real customs service is to destroy the livelihood of everyone enriched by the fake one; to build a real mining regime is to cut off the rents of everyone who lives on its absence. The reformer who imagines he is filling a vacuum is mistaken: there is no vacuum, there is an arrangement, and the arrangement is owned. He is taking the most valuable thing the powerful possess — their privileged access to unearned wealth — and they will fight to keep it with everything that access has bought them. This is why so many technically sound reforms die: the obstacle was never the design but that the design, if it succeeded, would take a great fortune from people strong enough to prevent it.

There is a further cost to concentration, and it falls on the strongman himself even when his intentions are sincere. It is not the cost he fears. He guards against enemies, betrayal, the sudden assault;

what undoes him is quieter — the slow capture of what he is able to know. When every decision runs through one man, the institutions that would have reported the truth to him atrophy, their independence having become an inconvenience. What remains around him are people whose standing depends on his favor, and such people describe the world as he prefers it, not as it is. Rivals learn to move his hand through intermediaries he trusts precisely because they seem disinterested. Warnings reach him unverifiable, flattery indistinguishable from intelligence. The ruler who has centralized everything has not made himself all-seeing; he has made himself blind, and his blindness is the most loyal servant his opponents possess.

This is why impartial enforcement is not only the citizen's protection but the ruler's. An institution structurally free to report honestly — a court that may rule against power, an auditor who cannot be dismissed for what he finds, a count that is real — is the only mechanism by which a leader can know whether his own state is working or being worked.

The leader who dismantles these in the name of control loses the very thing control was meant to secure: a true picture of his own country. The same self-binding institutions that protect the governed are the only ones that can keep the governor from being deceived. The keystone holds up the arch from both sides.

The resistance, then, is rational, not wicked, and the doctrine insists on seeing it clearly rather than moralizing. The men who defend the weak state are doing what anyone defending a source of wealth would do; their behavior is a response to incentives, not a defect of character, which is why exhortation does not move them and appeals to the national good bounce off. They will fight, and fight harder as the reform nears the core of their wealth. A reformer who expects the rightness of strong institutions to carry the day has mistaken the struggle: he is not persuading skeptics but taking property from its holders, and they know it before he does. The doctrine cannot dissolve this resistance.

What converts a reformer's temporary victory into a permanent one is, in the end, the self-binding institution — an arrangement defended by the powerful can only be replaced by an institution stronger than they are, one that goes on taking their privileged access even after the reformer who built it is gone.

The Non-Negotiable Separation

The deeper framing does not soften the concrete requirement; it sharpens it. The separation must be real, institutional, and enforced along both dimensions of the fusion — the political and the economic — because in Guinea the instruments of force have served both. Coercive power must never be turned against the people to protect those in power. The army, the police, and the security services must not be the means by which citizens who oppose a law are arrested, demonstrations are broken, opponents are jailed, critics are silenced, or those who challenge power are made to disappear. This is the first and gravest form the capture takes, and a republic in which the instruments of force answer to the holder of power rather than to the law is captured at its foundation, whatever its constitution says.

Coercive power must equally never be an instrument of economic capture. The army and the police must not be the means by which competitors are detained, routes protected, or access to the mining zones decided. Nor may armed authority control ports, customs, procurement, mining licenses, or commercial enforcement: the military's relationship to the economy is to protect it, not to participate in it, and the fully owned commercial empire that armed power builds elsewhere is the destination Guinea avoids only by separating that power now, before it entrenches. And armed authority must never be the arbiter of political competition, for security power that decides political outcomes is the mechanism by which the real map detaches from the formal one.

The principle beneath all of these is one: each power — political, economic, security, constitutional — must live inside the institution formally responsible for it, and be exercised through that institution rather than around it. In parallel, the military must receive what every professional military deserves: a clear constitutional mission to defend the sovereignty and territory of the Republic, adequate resources, modern training, professional advancement, institutional respect, and protection from political manipulation. The objective is not to weaken the military but to strengthen it — to let it focus on the mission only it can perform, and remove it from the commercial and political roles that corrode every army that takes them on. A professional army is itself an antidote to the network, because a real hierarchy cannot be a private instrument: when soldiers are paid by rank and promoted by merit, resourced by mission rather than loyalty to a faction, the formal chain of command becomes the real one, and the inner core that lets a favored few override it dissolves. Restoring the army's own formal map is inseparable from restoring the state's.

Whether power has genuinely moved into the institutions can be measured, and the doctrine insists it be measured rather than asserted. Can a contract survive a change of leadership? Can a regulator decide against a powerful actor and have the decision stand? Can a customs officer enforce the rule against someone connected? Can a citizen protest a policy without fear of the cell or worse? Can a procurement system reject a politically favored bidder? Can an institution keep functioning when a powerful individual leaves it? As the answers move toward yes, the civilian state is emerging. As long as they remain no, the formal map is decoration over a real map drawn elsewhere — and no number of elections, ministries, or constitutions will change it.

The mines are not the test. The state is the test. And the state is real only when the power that governs on paper is the same power that governs in fact — and when the force that power commands is turned toward the republic's defense, never against its own citizens.

Governing Question · The Cycle Question

Every leader in Guinea's history very likely began believing he would be the exception, and the wheel turned anyway. If you hold power now, that is the inheritance you sit inside, and the doctrine names it not to predict your failure but because pretending the pattern away is the first step in repeating it.

The question it cannot answer is whether the cycle can finally be broken — whether Guinea can build institutions strong enough to outlast successive leaderships, constrain the networks that reach for them, and stay legitimate no matter who holds office. Everything else in this doctrine depends on the answer. If institutions stay subordinate to whoever holds power, every reform reverses the moment power changes hands. If real power and legitimate power finally converge inside them, the transformation holds. No analysis can settle this; it is decided only by the accumulated choices of those who govern and those who are governed, over a horizon longer than any single term.

And here is the part that falls to you specifically: the cycle is broken not by a leader who concentrates power well, however benevolently, but by one who moves power out of his own hands and into institutions while he still holds it — the hardest act in the whole of this doctrine, and the only one that has ever broken the wheel. To break the cycle you must do the thing every figure before you found a reason not to do. The doctrine cannot make that choice for you. It can only tell you, as plainly as it knows how, that this is the choice on which all the rest depends.

Part XII: The Polycentric Republic

A country with one engine is a country with one point of failure. When a single city holds everything, it produces congestion at its center and abandonment everywhere else.

No country achieves durable development when one city monopolizes finance, administration, education, infrastructure, and opportunity while every other region waits for redistribution. The cost is paid twice over. The center chokes on its own success — housing it cannot supply, traffic it cannot move, services it cannot scale — while the regions that send it their most capable people are stripped of the very talent that might have built them. A single overloaded engine does not pull the country forward; it strains while the rest idles.

Guinea must become a polycentric republic — a nation where each region has a productive function connected to its genuine competitive advantages, not merely a political constituency connected to the capital by patronage.

Endowment is not advantage

Every region of Guinea holds something real to build on — proximity to resources, a fertile hinterland, a river basin, a border, a position where routes could meet, a highland climate, an ecosystem worth stewarding. But an endowment is not an advantage. It is latent potential that pays nothing until the building is done, earned against real constraints and real competitors, never a possession to be

assumed. The doctrine does not assign each region its function, because that assignment is not a doctrine's to make: it belongs to the government that must weigh real endowments against real costs, and to the regions that must earn their role rather than be granted it. What the doctrine insists on is only the principle — that every region be developed toward a productive function tied to its genuine advantage, not handed a place in line tied to its proximity to power. A region connected to the capital by patronage waits for redistribution. A region connected to the national economy by its own production does not wait at all.

National unity becomes more durable when every region has a productive role — not because the president visited, but because the economy arrived.

Part XIII: What Must Never Happen

Doctrines require prohibitions as much as prescriptions. The following are not recommendations. They are safeguards derived from the specific mechanisms by which Guinea and comparable countries have failed.

The Prohibitions

Resource revenues must never become a payroll expansion strategy. Hiring civil servants with mining revenue is political consumption disguised as development.

The military must never operate as a commercial actor. When it does, civilian reform encounters a structural obstacle with permanent capacity to resist.

State-owned enterprises must never become patronage vehicles. An enterprise existing to employ political supporters is a sustained tax on the productive economy.

Mining contracts must never be secret. Secrecy optimizes for elite benefit rather than national development.

Future production must never be secretly pledged. Borrowing against ore not yet mined, collateralized on revenues not yet earned, is how a state mortgages a generation it has not consulted. Resource-backed debt must face the same disclosure and parliamentary scrutiny as any contract — because a loan secured on tomorrow's ore commits

the nation as surely as a concession, and a debt hidden today is a crisis transferred to people who had no voice in it.

Infrastructure must never be selected primarily by political geography. A road that does not lower the cost of production is asphalt consumption.

Major rail and port infrastructure built for a single resource project must never be left as that project's private property. A railway or port engineered to move only one company's ore, closed to a region's agriculture and general freight, throws away most of the value the nation paid for in disruption, land, and risk. Such infrastructure must be common-carrier by law from the outset.

Vanity projects must never precede foundations. No national airline, smart city, prestige hospital, or high-speed rail until electricity, roads, skills, and food systems work. Delaying these is not lack of ambition. It is the definition of seriousness.

Resource wealth must never finance consumption before productive capacity. A boom that makes a country rich on paper while its farmers are undersold and its workshops cannot compete has not ended poverty. It has produced a richer version of the poverty it was meant to end — one import bill away from collapse the moment the ore runs out.

The gap between women's legal right to own land and their actual ownership of it must not be left in place. Women perform much of Guinea's agricultural labor yet hold title to only a small fraction of the land — not because the law forbids it, but because inheritance, titling defaults, and collateral requirements withhold in practice what the law permits on paper. That gap is a standing loss of productive capacity, closed by changing practice, not by citing the law.

Agricultural machinery, infrastructure, and equipment must never be procured without simultaneously building the maintenance capacity, spare parts supply chains, and trained mechanics required to keep them operational. An asset that cannot be maintained is not an investment. It is an expenditure.

Every project must leave behind more Guinean capability than existed before it began. Not concrete. Not equipment. Capability. Because capability compounds, and the direction chosen in the next decade determines which trajectory Guinea follows for the next generation.

Part XIV: The Corridor as an Economy

A corridor is not a road. A corridor is an economy — and a country that builds projects where it should build economies only grows poorer with better infrastructure.

Infrastructure does not create prosperity by itself.

Prosperity emerges when infrastructure connects producers, markets, labor, capital, knowledge, and institutions into functioning economic systems.

For this reason, Guinea should not think primarily in projects. It should think in systems — and the most useful name for the system that turns infrastructure into prosperity is the corridor.

From sector logic to corridor logic

The most important shift in development thinking is from sector logic to corridor logic. Sector logic asks what the agriculture ministry should do, what the transport ministry should build, each in its own column. Corridor logic asks what economic system should emerge along a line of movement — and forces integrated thinking, because a corridor only functions when all its components function at once: power, road and rail, skills, agriculture, logistics, customs, and institutions working as one system. A road built where a corridor was needed is infrastructure that does not connect — the most expensive way a poor country can fail. Where the cargo is bulk commodity over

distance, rail carries the tonnage and road carries the access, and the serious corridors need both; but the deeper point is that none of the parts is worth much alone. The corridor is the unit of prosperity. The project is not.

The discipline the corridor demands

Thinking in corridors is powerful precisely because it is dangerous — it is the kind of thinking that flatters a country into mistaking a map for an advantage, and the doctrine must therefore arm it with its own discipline. Consider the one corridor geography seems to hand Guinea for free: its landlocked neighbors. Mali has no port. Burkina Faso has no port. Niger has no port. A glance at the map says Guinea's coast is the natural Atlantic gateway for the southern Sahel, and that transit, warehousing, customs, fuel, and agro-processing could become national income the day Guinea stops being merely a coastal state and becomes a gateway state.

Then the doctrine turns its hard eye on its own case, and asks the question the flattering map invites everyone to skip: if the route to the Atlantic through Guinea is so natural, why does the cargo not already take it? The answer is the whole lesson. That trade does not move through open country; it moves along incumbent corridors built, financed, and habituated over decades — established freight forwarders, customs relationships, banking and insurance arrangements, and the plain inertia of a route traders already know and trust. Competing coastal states have spent a generation winning that cargo with deep ports and modernized links. A shipper does not switch because a map suggests a shorter line; he switches only when the total delivered cost — freight, time, reliability, paperwork, the risk of a road that closes in the rains — is decisively lower, and stays lower long enough to be trusted.

Naming this does not defeat the corridor. It disciplines it. A shorter distance to the sea is a real advantage, but a latent one, and it converts

into traffic only if three things are delivered rather than assumed: a cost-per-ton that beats the incumbent at the shipper's door and not merely on the map; a reliability a trader can stake a shipment on; and a stability of arrangement that does not evaporate with a change of government on either side of the border. Where these are met, geography finally pays. Where they are not, the shortest line on the map carries nothing, and the corridor becomes one more road that does not connect.

This is the standard the doctrine applies to every corridor a state might dream of, and it grants none of them an exemption: a corridor is not an advantage a country possesses because the map suggests it, but one it must earn against real competitors who started early. Think in economies, not roads — and then make the economy real against the world as it is, not the world as the map flatters it to be.

Governing Question · The Regional Integration Paradox

Every corridor a state might build rests on an assumption about other people's choices that the corridor itself cannot command: that a neighbour will prefer this route over the one it already uses, that a border will open to goods that compete with local production, that an informal trade will agree to be formalized. These are not engineering questions, and they are not settled by building. The infrastructure is the easy half; the assumption buried beneath it is the half that decides whether the corridor carries an economy or stands empty.

None of these neighbor behaviors are guaranteed by Guinea's infrastructure investment alone. Dakar's port has decades of established relationships with Malian traders. Senegal has domestic agricultural producers to protect. Mali's government benefits from taxing informal border flows. The governing question the doctrine cannot answer is what bilateral diplomacy, trade agreements, regional institutional

frameworks, and sustained relationship-building are required to make neighboring countries willing partners in Guinea's corridor strategy.

Geography creates opportunity. Diplomacy turns it into indispensability — or fails to, and leaves the opportunity where it lay. The doctrine establishes the geographic logic and the standard the corridor must meet; whether the neighbors are won is decided at tables it cannot sit at, by the people who will.

The decision that turns a route into an economy

One principle decides whether any corridor becomes an economy or stays a route, and it is worth stating on its own. Infrastructure built for a mine is the largest transport asset a resource state will ever lay down, and it must be treated as a national asset, not a single company's private siding. A railway that moves only ore has wasted most of its value the day it is finished. A railway that also moves a region's harvest, its inputs, and its people is a development corridor — the same steel, carrying two entirely different states. Which one a country gets is not an engineering outcome; it is a decision about whether the infrastructure is open by right to those who did not finance it. That single decision — carry the ore alone, or carry the economy with it — is the difference between a mine with a railway attached and a country with a spine.

Does it make productive activity more rewarding than political access? If yes, the corridor advances the doctrine. If no, it is merely another road.

The Final Doctrine

Guinea does not need another plan.

Guinea needs a changed reward system.

The evidence that Guineans want to build productive enterprises already exists. There are well over a hundred thousand registered small businesses in Guinea, a large share of them owned by women. Most young Guineans, asked, say they would rather build their own enterprise than hold a government post. The country has millions of hectares of arable land and farmers ready to work it. The entrepreneurial spirit is not missing. The agricultural potential is not missing. What is missing is a state that rewards production rather than suppresses it. What is missing is infrastructure that makes farming commercially viable. What is missing is a credit system that finances enterprise rather than ignores it. What is missing is a land system that gives women the collateral to build businesses from the labor they already provide.

The doctrine is complete when its first principle becomes self-enforcing — when productive activity is so consistently more rewarding than political access that talent, capital, and ambition reorient without requiring constant political pressure.

The sequence of those decisions is the work.

The courage to hold the sequence against the constant pressure of short-term political incentives is the test.

When engineers are valued above brokers —

When exporters outperform intermediaries —

When manufacturers outperform monopolists —

When a young Guinean with technical skill earns more and rises faster than one with political connections —

When the driver who moves goods along a working corridor earns more than the official who used to control the checkpoint —

When a Malian trader chooses Guinea's port because it is genuinely faster and cheaper, not because someone was paid —

When a gold miner in Mandiana formalizes because the formal system genuinely serves him better than the informal one —

When a woman owns the land she farms and can borrow against it to build an enterprise from it —

When a farmer can move her harvest to market on infrastructure open to her, rather than watch it rot for want of a road —

When a general understands that the republic he protects is stronger precisely because he does not manage its ports —

When a minister knows that the contract she signs will be read tomorrow by every citizen with a phone —

When the hundreds of thousands of young Guineans who enter the labor market each year find that building something is more rewarding than knowing someone —

That is the moment Guinea begins to transform.

Not before.

Simandou will provide revenue. Revenue is not transformation.

Corridors and infrastructure will provide connectivity. Connectivity is not transformation.

The many thousands of small businesses already operating despite the broken reward system are not transformation. They are proof that transformation is possible — evidence that Guineans will build the productive economy the moment the state stops making it harder than controlling access to value.

Institutions are transformation.

The discipline to sequence investments correctly is transformation.

The insistence that every project leave behind more Guinean capability than existed before it began is transformation.

The recognition that an economy operates below its capacity while much of its agricultural labor comes from women who hold title to only a small fraction of its land — and the resolve to close that gap — is transformation.

The Productive Republic

All of this has a name, and the name is not a slogan. The Productive Republic is not a territory, a party, or an era. It is a condition — the condition a country reaches when producing value has finally become more rewarding than controlling access to it. It can exist in a single ministry before it exists in the nation, and it can be lost in the nation while it survives in a single honest office. It is built or abandoned one decision at a time.

And it has a people. The citizens of the Productive Republic are not defined by region, by name, by faith, or by who they know. They are those who build, grow, make, repair, carry, teach, heal, serve, and govern without needing access to be legitimate — those whose standing comes from what they contribute rather than whom they can reach. The farmer who feeds a market, the technician who keeps the machine running, the teacher who builds capacity that compounds, the official who enforces a rule against a powerful friend, the soldier who guards the republic without owning a piece of it, the woman who works the land and is finally allowed to own it — these are its citizens. They already exist. They have always existed. The doctrine does not create them. It asks only for a state that stops punishing them for building, and starts rewarding them for it. That state is the Productive Republic, and its citizens are already here, waiting to be governed by a system that finally has a place for what they can do.

Governing Question · The Final Governing Question

This doctrine has named the problem, established the principle, designed the institutions, mapped the geography, and located the governing questions that only reality can answer. The one question it cannot answer about itself is this: who reads it, who acts on it, and whether the people with the power to implement it are the same people who have been shaped by the system it is trying to change.

Reform has almost always been carried out by people partly shaped by the system they changed. The doctrine cannot guarantee its own implementation by actors free of the contradictions it names. What it can do — what it has tried to do throughout — is provide a standard clear enough, honest enough, and specific enough that people who read it know what they are aiming for, know what will try to stop them, and know the difference between genuine transformation and its simulation.

The rest belongs to Guinea.

Guinea's future will not be determined by the scale of its mineral deposits. Those deposits already exist. It will not be determined by the number of development plans produced. Guinea has never lacked plans. It will be determined by whether this generation of Guineans — leaders, citizens, soldiers, entrepreneurs, farmers, engineers, miners, women, and teachers — can build and sustain a state in which producing value is more rewarding than controlling access to value.

The mines are not the test.

The state is the test.

GUINEA

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About the Author

Abdourahamane Diallo

Abdourahamane Diallo is a strategist working on statecraft and political economy, with a focus on state capacity, economic transformation, and development in resource-rich countries.

This doctrine is offered as an independent contribution to Guinea's development debate. It is not affiliated with any political party, faction, ethnic constituency, or international institution, and any serious leader may adopt it on its merits.

Author's Note

I have spent my life moving between two Guineas.

The first is the Guinea that formed me. The second is the Guinea I believe is possible. Everything in this doctrine exists in the distance between those two countries.

The Guinea that formed me is not poor in the way people describe poverty from the outside. It has land, rivers, minerals, and a young population of extraordinary capacity. It has faith, family structure, discipline, and people willing to work. What it has lacked was never potential. What it has lacked is a system that rewards potential. I absorbed this before I had words for it — watching capable people blamed for failing inside structures that were never designed to let them succeed; watching the decisive question in a young person's life become not what can you produce but who do you know, who can open the door, who can protect you. That observation is the seed of this doctrine.

I came to America as an immigrant, and America gave me the second understanding. It taught me something an outsider feels more sharply than someone born into it: development is not magic. It is organized behavior, repeated through institutions. Credit systems, courts, universities, local government, financial markets, the unglamorous rules that hold — these are invisible to those who inherit them and astonishing to those who arrive without them. Guinea had shown me the human cost of institutional weakness. America showed me what institutional density actually looks like. Living between the

two gave me a double vision I have never lost. Guinea gave me the urgency. America gave me the comparison. Together they produced the question beneath this entire doctrine: why should a Guinean child have to leave Guinea before his talent can be rewarded?

The understanding that shaped this doctrine most came from a habit of reading systems rather than events. The serious question to ask of any moment is not what just happened but what holds it up: what would have to break for this to fail, and how a shock would travel through the whole. That habit became the spine of how I read Guinea's present moment. A mine is an event; a state is a system. A road is an event; logistics is a system. A loan program is an event; productive capacity is a system. Confusing events for systems is how countries waste historic opportunities. That distinction runs through every chapter that follows.

There is one point of genuine optimism beneath everything that follows, and it comes from watching it proven in practice: Guineans do not lack ambition. Give young people structure, mentorship, and a real opportunity — rather than waiting for government to do what a community can begin itself — and ability turns into achievement. Build the right structure, and people rise.

The method behind it is simple and runs through every chapter: look at incentives rather than speeches, look at who controls the timetable and who benefits from delay, and the future becomes less mysterious. A country's direction is rarely hidden in what its powerful say; it is legible in what its arrangements reward. This doctrine is built from that habit of mind.

But the central idea here did not come from analysis. It came from life.

I watched intelligent, educated young people whose first serious career strategy was not to build expertise but to find someone powerful — and they were not wrong; they were responding rationally to the economy around them. I watched businesspeople invest more in relationships than in competitiveness, because relationships opened

doors that quality alone could not. And I saw it most clearly in the story of the agricultural funds: patient capital made available to producers, which failed on both sides at once. The institutions lacked the systems to identify and support real producers. Many recipients were not real entrepreneurs; some had access rather than a business plan, and the money became a car, a house, a journey, or a kickback. That experience revealed something deeper than corruption. When capital arrives before capability, money does not create entrepreneurs — it creates extraction. The principle capability must precede capital was born there. The same truth rusts in fields across Guinea, in machines distributed without the mechanics, parts, and training to sustain them — not a failure of farming, but a failure of sequencing.

And I saw the young people leave. The routes north across the Sahara, the routes west through the Americas. We tell ourselves these are stories of desperation, but often the people who leave are among the most resourceful and capable — the ones with the courage, the means, and the networks that a productive economy should capture most urgently. Guinea does not merely fail to create opportunity for them. It exports the very people who could build it. That made the doctrine's central claim undeniable to me: the deepest problem is a reward system that has made access more profitable than production, and until that changes, nothing else will hold.

I wrote this doctrine now because Guinea is approaching one of the most consequential economic moments in its history, and I did not see a governing philosophy serious enough to discipline it. There are plans, speeches, slogans, and donor frameworks. There was no doctrine asking the hard question: how does Guinea convert temporary mineral wealth into permanent productive capacity? The danger of the Simandou era is as historic as its promise. If institutions are weak when the money arrives, mineral wealth does not heal the system — it hands the same political economy more to capture.

My stake is not abstract. Guinea is where my family comes from and where my identity was formed. It is where millions of capable

people still live below their potential — not because they lack the will to build, but because the system around them rewards access more than production. I do not want Guinea to become another country that had everything and built nothing durable. I want a state that rewards builders. A country where a young person does not need political access to succeed. Where farmers can become commercial producers. Where the women who work the land can own and build from it. Where soldiers protect the republic rather than manage its economy. Where foreign capital leaves Guinean capability behind. Where the mine finances the strategy without becoming the strategy.

This book is offered in that spirit. The doctrine that follows is not a plan and not a platform. It is a framework for the Guinean state — written so that any serious leader, of any background, can take it up, apply it, and be held to its principles by the citizens it is meant to serve.

What matters is not who wrote it.

What matters is whether Guinea builds a state in which producing value becomes more rewarding than controlling access to value.

Everything that follows is an attempt to answer that question.

Where This Doctrine Stands

This doctrine was built from observation and experience, not assembled from a reading list. Its claims were reached by watching Guinea — the young people who leave, the capital that fails because it arrives before capability, the land no one can prove they own, the state that grows richer while the country does not. Only afterward did it become clear how often those conclusions converge with what serious thinkers, working from entirely different evidence, had already established. That convergence is set down here honestly, because agreement reached independently is not borrowing. It is corroboration — and a doctrine whose findings line up with what others discovered by separate roads has reason to be trusted, not reason to apologize.

What follows names the traditions this doctrine converges with, field by field. In each case the doctrine reached its conclusion from Guinea's own evidence; the established theory is named as corroboration, not as source.

In economics. The central claim — that a society's reward system, not its stock of talent, decides whether ambition flows into producing value or into capturing it — is the pattern William Baumol named as the difference between productive and unproductive entrepreneurship, the allocation of the same talent by the rules of the game. What this doctrine calls controlling access to value, economics calls rent-seeking, the line of work running from Tullock and Krueger to Bhagwati. That untitled land is wealth that cannot work — dead capital — is Hernando de Soto's. That mineral abundance can improv-

erish rather than enrich a weak state is the resource-curse literature, from Auty, who named it, to Sachs and Warner. And that capital deployed before the capacity to use it merely rents ability rather than building it draws on two distinct strands: the idea of absorptive capacity, a society's power to take in and use what it is given, and Arrow's learning-by-doing, the way capability is built through the act of building itself.

In politics and institutions. The access economy — a society that holds itself stable by rationing opportunity to a connected few — is what North, Wallis, and Weingast called a limited-access order, set against the open-access order this doctrine works toward. That a nation's fate turns on whether its institutions include or extract is the ground Acemoglu and Robinson have spent careers establishing. The self-binding at the heart of the Guardianship Trap is the problem of credible commitment, traced by North and Weingast to the institutions that bound the English crown, and present wherever elites make the rule of law credible by surrendering their own exemption from it; the older image is Ulysses, who kept faith by having himself bound to the mast. That the ruler with a lasting stake invests while the one who expects a short season strips the country bare is Mancur Olson's stationary bandit; that the army must protect the republic without governing it is the substance of Huntington on civil-military relations; and that the strongman who centralizes everything goes blind because no one near him is free to tell the truth is the autocrat's information problem.

In justice and law. That no one who profits from a judgment may render it is *nemo iudex in causa sua*, among the oldest rules of natural justice. That fair rules are those one would accept without knowing which side of them one will stand on is the spirit of Rawls. And the doctrine's central legal claim — that a right which exists on paper but dies in practice is not a milder right but its absence — belongs to the rule-of-law tradition, to Fuller's insistence that a law which does not

bind is not yet law, and to the realist distinction between the law in books and the law in action.

In behavior and society. That people respond rationally to the incentives a system presents — that the broker and the emigrant are reasoning correctly about the world they were given — is the premise of rational-choice analysis. That citizens fall back on their own group when institutions will not protect them impartially is the instrumentalist reading of ethnicity, group loyalty as the only insurance a weak state leaves available. That a reform imposing concentrated costs for diffuse benefits struggles to find defenders is Olson's logic of collective action. And that impartial enforcement is what lets strangers trust enough to trade is the work on institutional trust and transaction costs associated with North, Putnam, and Fukuyama.

In statecraft and history. Writing the rules that govern the wealth before it arrives is constitutional pre-commitment, binding the sovereign in advance; and the founder who builds institutions designed to outlast and constrain him stands in the oldest line in political thought, the law-giver from Solon and Lycurgus to Machiavelli's founder, whose distinction is precisely that he builds an order that no longer needs him. The doctrine's counsel on surviving reform is in open dialogue with Machiavelli's Prince — keeping his rule that benefits be conferred gradually and the people's favor be made a shield against the powerful, while deliberately breaking his rule that injuries be inflicted all at once, because a reformer who must govern the wounded afterward cannot afford the permanent enemies a conqueror can. That a country with a single center is a country with a single point of failure is the case for polycentricity in the sense of Ostrom, and the elementary logic of resilience.

This doctrine claims none of those insights as original to it. What it claims is the assembly: the welding of these separate findings into a single framework, in plain language, aimed at one country at one moment, and carried from analysis into a usable standard for the Guinean state. The thinkers above reached their conclusions from data

and history. This doctrine reached its own from a life lived between two Guineas. That they meet in the same place is the strongest evidence either can offer that the place is real.

Those Who Have Done This

The theorists named the patterns. Others lived them — rulers and reformers who faced, in office and under real pressure, the exact choices this doctrine describes. They are gathered here not as heroes to imitate in every respect, for several were also hard or worse, but as proof that the doctrine's demands have been met by real people in real history, and that its warnings have real graves behind them. The pattern is what matters; the names are evidence that the pattern is not a dream.

The founder who surrendered power. The doctrine's hardest demand — that a leader build institutions to outlast and bind himself, then step back — has been met, rarely, and remembered for exactly that reason. Cincinnatus took absolute power in a Roman emergency, won, and returned to his farm. George Washington resigned his military commission at the height of his authority and later declined to hold office for life, fixing by example the limit no law yet required. Nelson Mandela took power after a struggle that would have justified holding it, served a single term, and built a constitutional order designed to constrain whoever came next, himself included. Each chose the cage over the throne; each is honored less for what he seized than for what he let go.

The state that disciplined its resource wealth. The doctrine's Resource Constitution — rules written before the flood, revenue saved against the future — is not hypothetical. Botswana, at independence one of the poorest countries on earth, used diamond revenue to build

institutions, schools, and reserves rather than a ruling-family fortune, and became one of Africa's steadiest economies. Norway placed its oil revenue in a sovereign fund governed by rules stronger than any single government, and spends only the return, not the principal — the constitution-before-the-flood, written down and obeyed. Against them stand the cautionary cases the doctrine names elsewhere, where the same underground wealth, met by a weak state, financed dependency and collapse rather than capacity.

The state that built capability instead of renting it. The doctrine's insistence that capability must precede capital, and that foreign expertise be a bridge and not a substitute, was lived by the states that rose fastest in the last century. South Korea and Singapore began with few natural advantages and converted each foreign project, each period of assistance, into domestic skill that remained — engineers, managers, regulators, institutions — until they no longer needed to rent what they had learned to do. Their example carries the doctrine's own honest complication, addressed next.

The genuinely ambiguous — builder or strongman. The doctrine insists that the builder and the tyrant cannot always be told apart while the story is still running, and history supplies exactly that ambiguity. Several of the leaders who built capability and disciplined development also concentrated power, silenced rivals, and ruled with a hard hand — Lee Kuan Yew in Singapore, Park Chung-hee in South Korea, Deng Xiaoping in China among them. Some of what they built outlasted them and bound their successors; some of what they did the finished state they enabled would never permit. They are placed here not as models to copy whole, but as the living form of the doctrine's central uncertainty: the same concentration of power served construction in one case and mere domination in another, and in real time those enduring it could not always tell which they were living through. That is precisely the doctrine's warning, drawn from life rather than theory.

The reformers who defended the count and the law. The doctrine's claim that institutions must be made to bind the powerful, and

elections trusted before politics can become a contest over governing rather than over the machinery of the count, was won slowly and at cost wherever it was won at all — in the long histories by which courts in various countries became able to rule against rulers, and tax and customs services became too professional to be private instruments. These victories rarely carry a single famous name, because their signature is precisely that no one person remained indispensable. That anonymity is the proof that the work succeeded.

None of these figures resolves the doctrine's deepest problem, because none could: each was a particular person in a particular moment, and the doctrine cannot manufacture another. What they establish is narrower and still decisive — that every demand this doctrine makes has, somewhere, by someone, actually been met, and every danger it names has, somewhere, actually arrived. The doctrine asks Guinea to join the first list and escape the second. Both are possible. Both have been done. The choosing is what remains.